MODULE 00 · AMBITIOUS ENTREPRENEURSHIP

No-Bullshit Entrepreneurship

What kills startups, and what will this course demand from you?

COURSE PATH

00 01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08 09 10 11 12

COURSE MATERIAL · SCAN NOW

All slides live on GitHub

The newest version, free, no account needed

github.com/BaNburger/
AmbitiousEntrepreneurship

1. **Open the link**
   github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship
2. **Go to modules**
   then 00-kickoff
3. **Click the lecture PDF**
   M00_Lecture_No-Bullshit-Entrepreneurship.pdf, download top right

Public course repository of Ambitious Entrepreneurship. The QR code opens github.com/BaNburger/AmbitiousEntrepreneurship.

WHERE WE ARE · THE COURSE

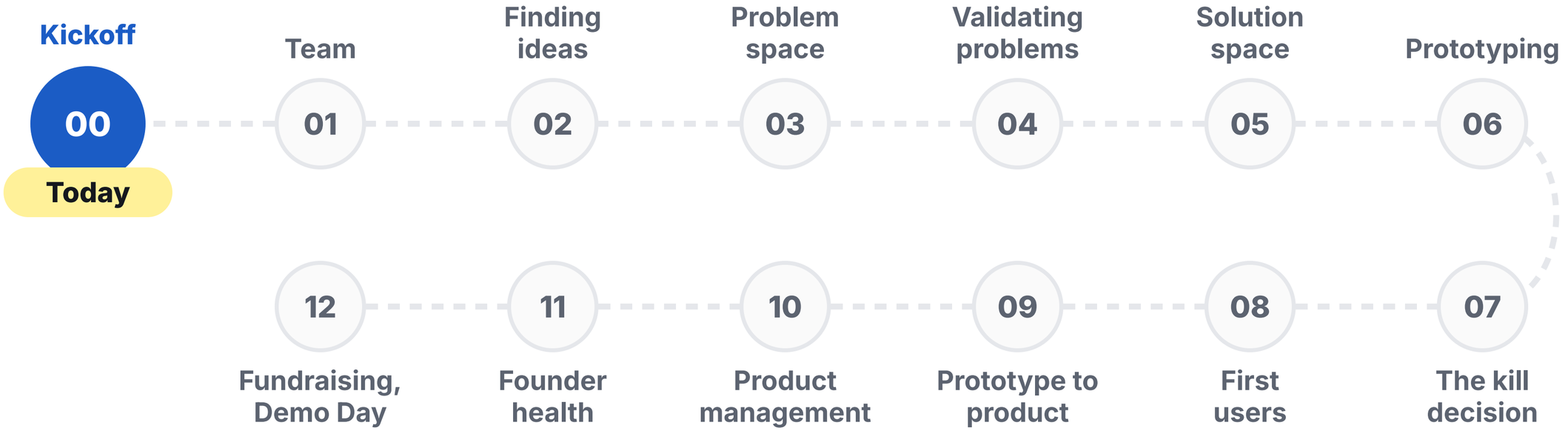
Session one of thirteen

From first idea to first revenue. Where teams get to:

A problem worth fixing, with names
Problem space (M03)

An MVP people use without help
Prototyping (M06)

First customers who are strangers
First users (M08)



CHECK-IN · SHOW OF HANDS

How big could your startup get?

Side income

a good one

50 people

a solid company

Unicorn

valued over $1 billion

Next Google

the moonshot

Logos are trademarks of their owners.

Aim it: why now, and why you

The companies founded now will shape the next 50 years, so why not yours?

01 Aim it: why now, and why you
02 Ground it: start from a problem
03 Test it: one loop a week
04 How this course works
05 Wrap-up and check-out
06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

INPUT 1 OF 3 · AIM IT · THREE QUESTIONS

Why you, and why now?

1



Why is now a good time to start?

2



Do you need to be special to found?

3



How big should you aim?

WHY NOW, WHY YOU

The companies founded now will shape how we see the world for the next

50 years

The best time to start in decades.

Maybe in 50 years.

WHY NOW · EVERY TRANSITION

At every transition, a new giant took the next step

The old giant missed it. The next step is still open

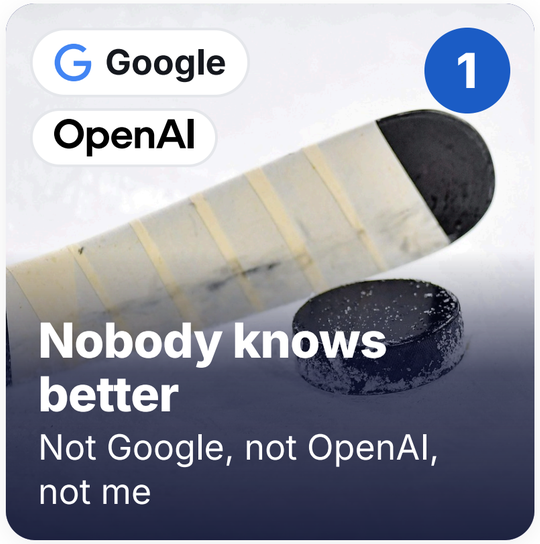
OLYMPIA	**Missed electronics** Asian electronics and the PC won. Works closed in 1992, 3,600 jobs	IBM
IBM	**Missed the PC's software** IBM built the PC in 1981. Microsoft kept the rights to DOS	Microsoft
Microsoft	**Missed search and mobile** Gates calls losing to Android his "greatest mistake ever"	Google
Google	**Missed the chatbot** Google published the transformer in 2017. OpenAI shipped ChatGPT in 2022	OpenAI
OpenAI	**The next step** Nobody knows yet	? your startup

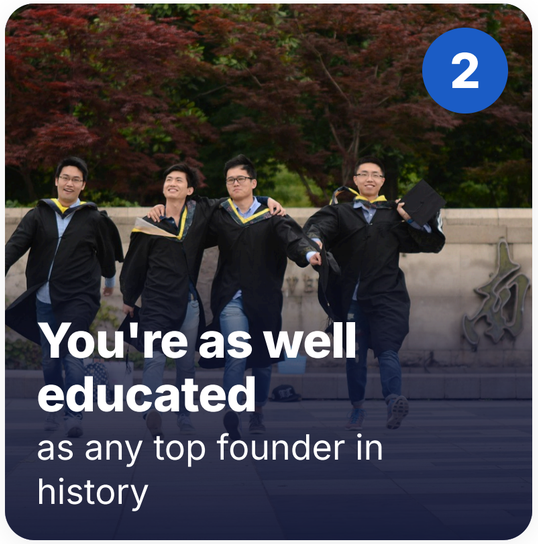
DATA Olympia closure decided December 1991 (Weser-Kurier). MS-DOS rights (Computer History Museum). Gates (CNBC, 24 June 2019). Vaswani et al. (2017). Logos are trademarks of their owners.

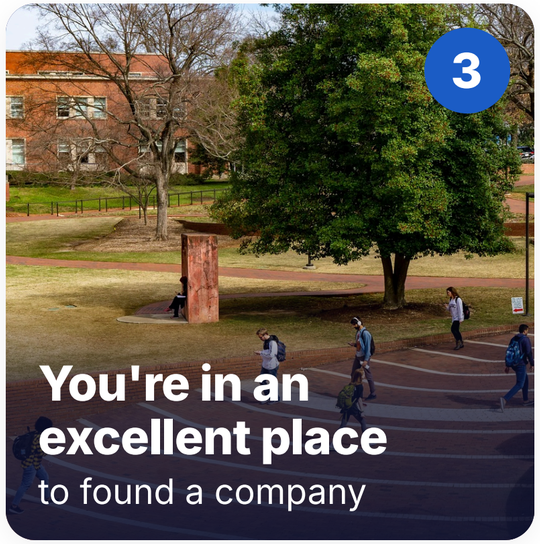
WHY YOU, WHY NOW · FOUR REASONS

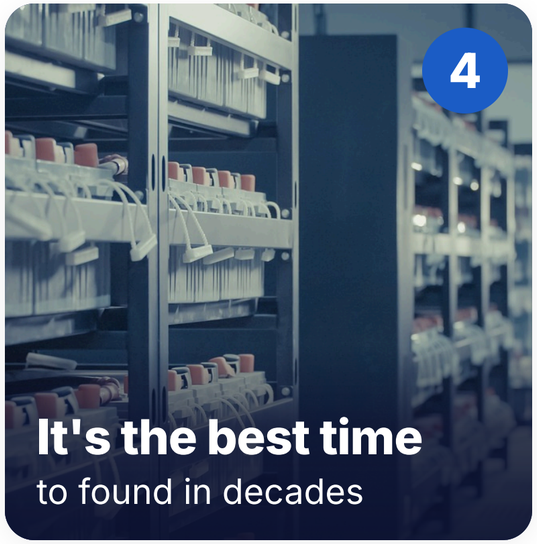
Nobody knows better than you. So go build

Nobody knows where the puck is going









So: go build.

FRAMEWORK "Skate to where the puck is going", Walter Gretzky's advice to his son Wayne (Gretzky & Reilly, 1990). Photos: soerli, MonsterLee, 16081684 and Akela999 on Pixabay. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

WHY NOW · DALIO'S BIG CYCLE, MY READ

Dalio sees a turn coming. I see an opening

Ray Dalio puts us late in a cycle of about 75 years, just before the breakdown



My read for founders

A productivity crisis exposes slow incumbents

Capital exists, but it flows to few. Earn it with evidence

Climate, security and demography need new solutions

FRAMEWORK Dalio, R. (2025). How Countries Go Broke: The Big Cycle. Avid Reader Press. Dalio (2026, March 14), Fortune: "We are now in a new Stage 5".

WHY YOU

They weren't better prepared than you

Age and education when they started

19 Microsoft

Bill Gates

Harvard, left without a degree · 1975

21 Apple

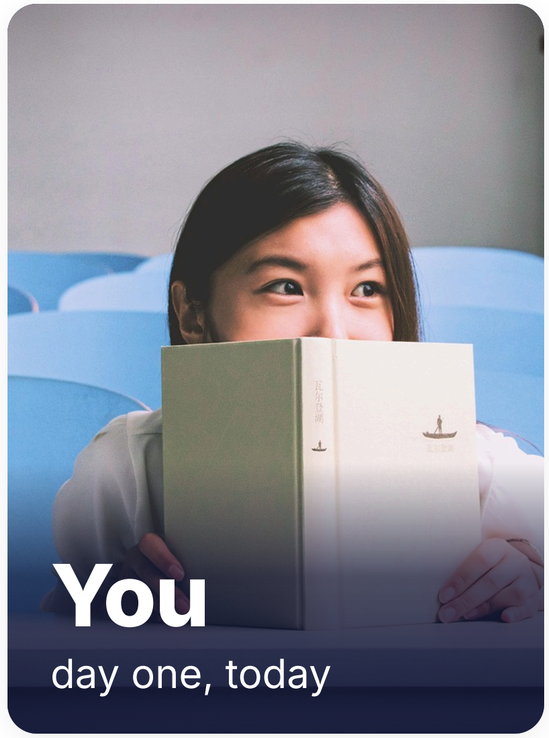
Steve Jobs

One semester at Reed College · 1976

25 Google

Larry Page & Sergey Brin

Stanford PhD students, never finished · 1998



28 SAP

Hasso Plattner

Engineer, left IBM with four colleagues · 1972

30 Nvidia

Jensen Huang

Chip designer, master's from night classes · 1993

30 SIEMENS

Werner von Siemens

Artillery school, no university · 1847

DATA Ages from birth and founding dates, education at founding. Wikipedia, retrieved 2026-10-19. Photo: Pexels on Pixabay. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

BUT…

~~But I'm not an engineer…~~

Yes, you can build it!

~~But we don't have a GmbH…~~

Yes, you can ship it!

~~But we don't have a patent…~~

Customers don't buy patents!

~~But we didn't get a grant…~~

Customers can pay you!

THE BASE RATE

Most new businesses* don't reach year five

Germany, % of new enterprises still active, by year founded

Still active after 1 year · founded 2019

72%

After 3 years · founded 2017

48%

After 5 years · founded 2015

37%

* Not all new businesses are startups.

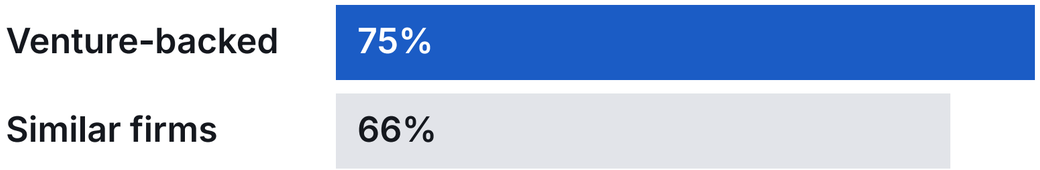


DATA Eurostat, business demography (bd_9bd_sz_cl_r2), Germany, survival rates for reference year 2020, industry, construction and services. Bars to scale. Photo: HOCKULUS on Pixabay.

BE AMBITIOUS

A big idea fails about as often as a small one. So aim for the next Google

Shut down by 2007 · % of US firms founded 1986 to 1997



Aim big. Start narrow.

Facebook began at one campus.

RESEARCH Kerr, Nanda & Rhodes-Kropf (2014), Journal of Economic Perspectives, US Census data, bars to scale. "Start narrow" after Graham (2012). Logos are trademarks of their owners.

A TIER LIST OF STARTUP IDEAS

Aim for S. Stay out of the tarpit

Thought experiment: in one sentence, what do all tarpit ideas share? All wrapper-zone ideas? What separates S from D?

S Moonshots	The next Google · Industrial capabilities in space
A Unsexy plumbing	Compliance paperwork for small factories · AI-native compliance infrastructure
B Crowded trades	Yet another AI note-taker
C Wrapper zone	Chat with your files · Copilot for dog walkers
D Tarpit ideas	Restaurant & event discovery · An app to plan hangouts with friends · Trading tools for day traders
F	Fridge inventory app · A social network for pet owners · Investing your friends' money on Reddit tips

Tarpits, copilots and the Reddit fund after Caldwell and Seibel's YC tarpit videos, the pet network after Graham (2012), space and compliance from YC's Requests for Startups (2026).

NOW YOU · ALONE · 2 MINUTES

Where does your idea land?

! YOUR STARTING POINT

Place it on the tier list

No idea yet? Take a frustration you saw someone fight last month.

→ Write your idea, problem or technology in one line
→ Which tier? Be honest
→ Write the one belief about customers it rests on
→ Like: "Lab managers would pay to stop tracking reagent orders by hand"

Output One line, one tier, one belief **Minutes** 2

S	**Moonshots**
A	**Unsexy plumbing**
B	**Crowded trades**
C	**Wrapper zone**
D	**Tarpit ideas**
F	**Fridge inventory apps**

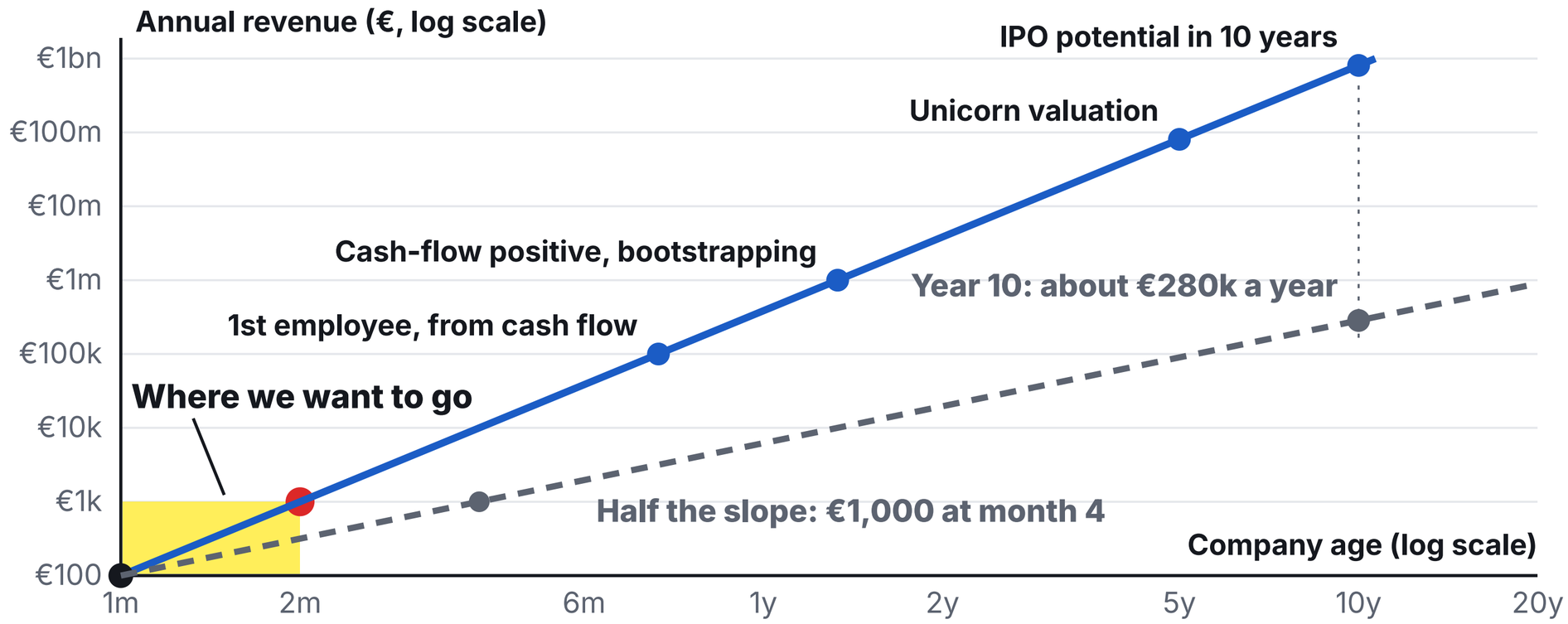
2:00

ILLUSTRATIVE Example belief ("Lab managers", not "companies").

REALITY CHECK · THE LONG GAME

How long do you want to take?

Half the slope, and €1 million a year takes 21 years instead of 16 months



ILLUSTRATIVE Both lines are power laws from the same start, €100 in month one: revenue ×10 for each doubling of age, and ×3.2 at half the slope.

INPUT 1 OF 3 · AIM IT · THE ANSWERS

Aim it: aim big, start narrow

1



Why is now a good time to start?

At every transition a new giant appeared. The next seat is still open

2



Do you need to be special to found?

No. They weren't better prepared than you, and you can build and ship it

3



How big should you aim?

Big. A big idea fails about as often as a small one. Start narrow

INPUT 2 OF 3 · CHAPTER 2 OF 6

Ground it: start from a problem

Every tool made building easier, but finding what people pay for never got easier.

01 ~~Aim it: why now, and why you~~

02 **Ground it: start from a problem**

03 **Test it: one loop a week**

04 How this course works

05 Wrap-up and check-out

06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

INPUT 2 OF 3 · GROUND IT · THREE QUESTIONS

What kills startups?

1



What kills most startups?

2



Which advice can wait?

3



Where should you start?

THE #1 KILLER · 101 POST-MORTEMS

"Tackling problems that are interesting to solve rather than those that serve a market need"

42% no market need

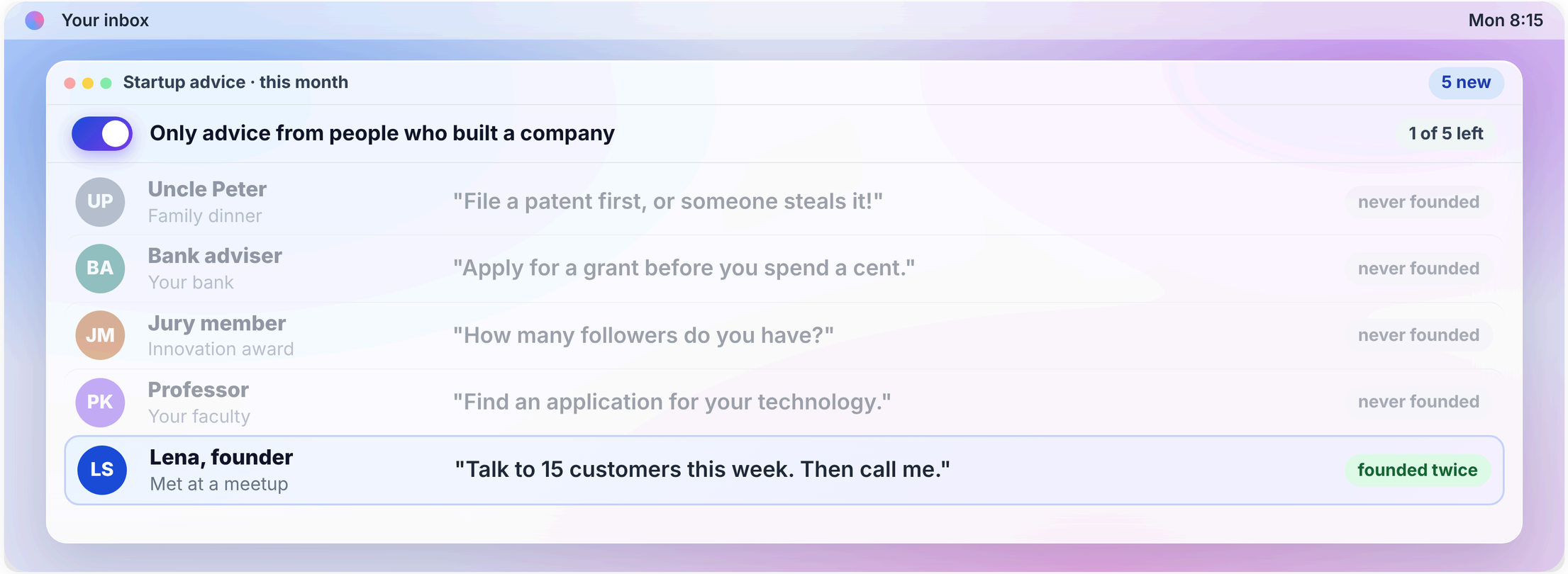
The #1 reason.

Not cash. Not competitors.

DATA CB Insights (2019). The top 20 reasons startups fail. 101 startup post-mortems.

WHO IS TALKING?

Driving lessons from someone who never drove?



ILLUSTRATIVE Mock-up, names made up. Michael Seibel (YC, 2024) says the same with "acting advice from someone who's not worked as an actor ...".

WHAT PEOPLE ASK YOU, AND WHAT MATTERS



~~Do you have a patent?~~

~~Did you apply for grants?~~

~~How many followers?~~

~~How many downloads?~~



Who has the problem?

Who paid?

What did you learn since last time?

> **Get a board of advisers. Partner with big companies. […] Get a patent strategy. […] And the product is like an afterthought.**

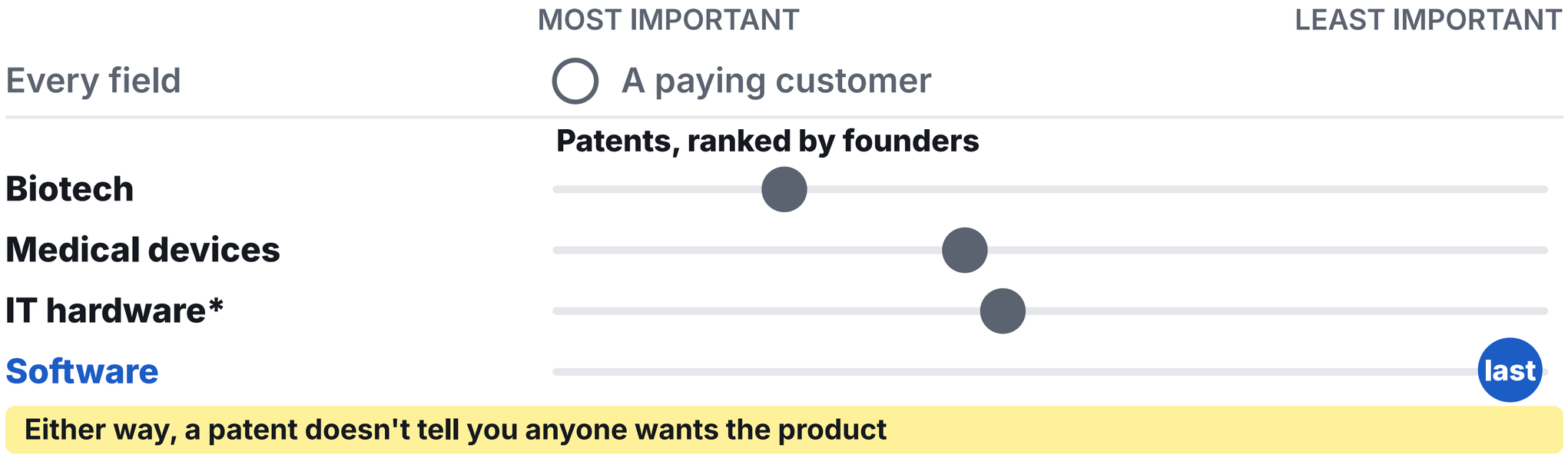
Michael Seibel, Y **Y Combinator**, on the advice founders get outside the Bay Area

YC Caldwell, D., & Seibel, M. (2024, August 6). The problem with startup "experts". Y Combinator, YouTube. Read in a transcript copy. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

PATENTS

Patents matter in biotech. In software they come last

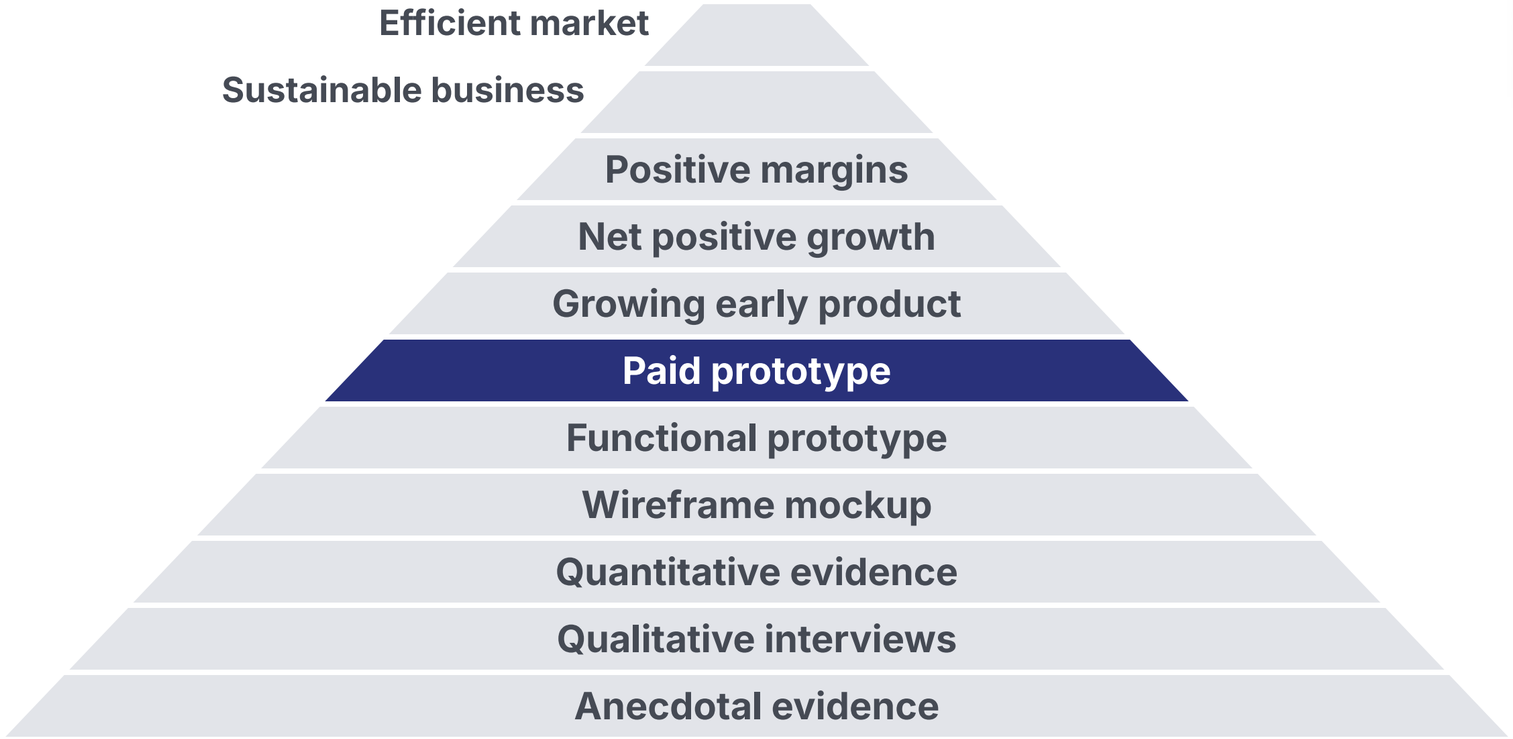
How 1,332 young tech companies ranked patents as protection



RESEARCH Graham, S., Merges, R., Samuelson, P., & Sichelman, T. (2009). High technology entrepreneurs and the patent system. Berkeley Technology Law Journal. *Venture-backed. Dots show the order, not distances. The top row is the course's rule, not a survey item.

GRANTS

A grant buys you time, not evidence



A grant buys time
Not on the pyramid

Growth phase

Solution space

Problem space



VANITY METRICS

Count what customers did, not what you collected

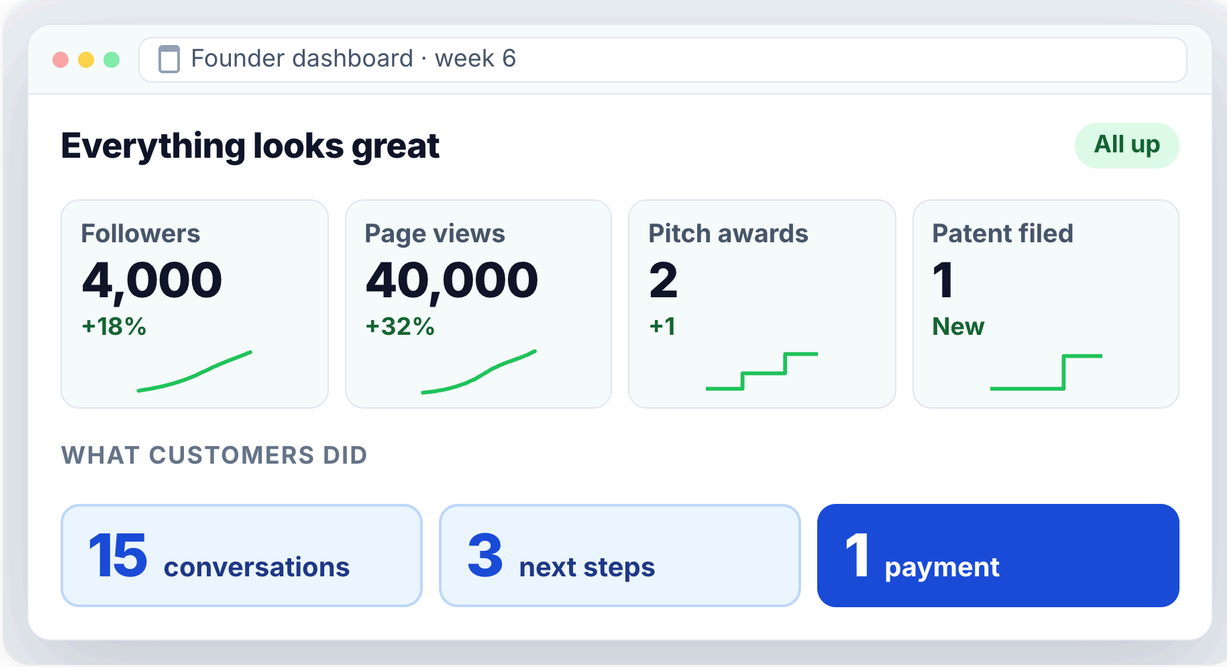
Validated learning is the only progress early on

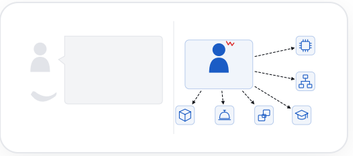
COLLECTED

4,000 followers, 2 pitch awards, 1 patent filed, 40,000 page views

LEARNED

15 conversations, 3 next steps, 1 payment



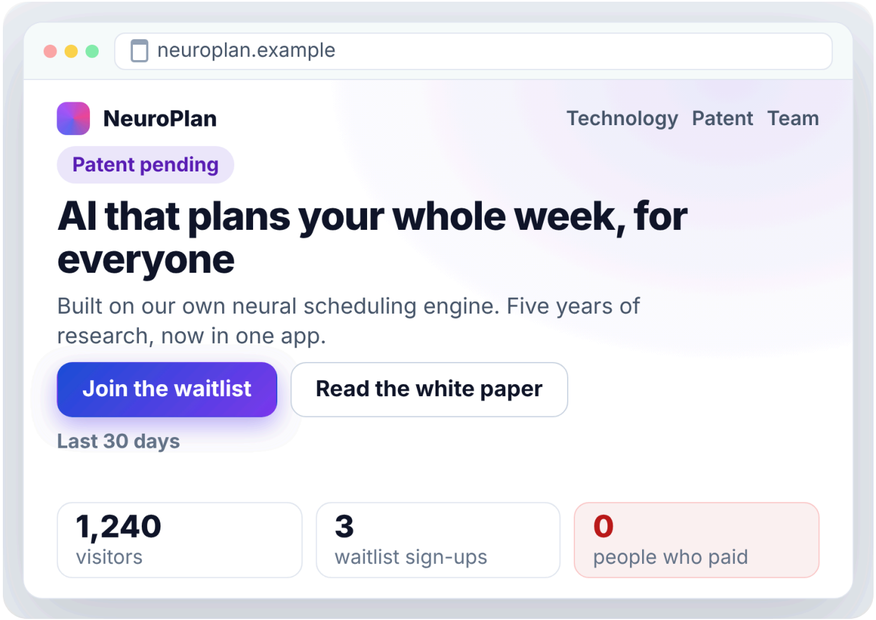


TECHNOLOGY PUSH

Start from a problem, not from your technology

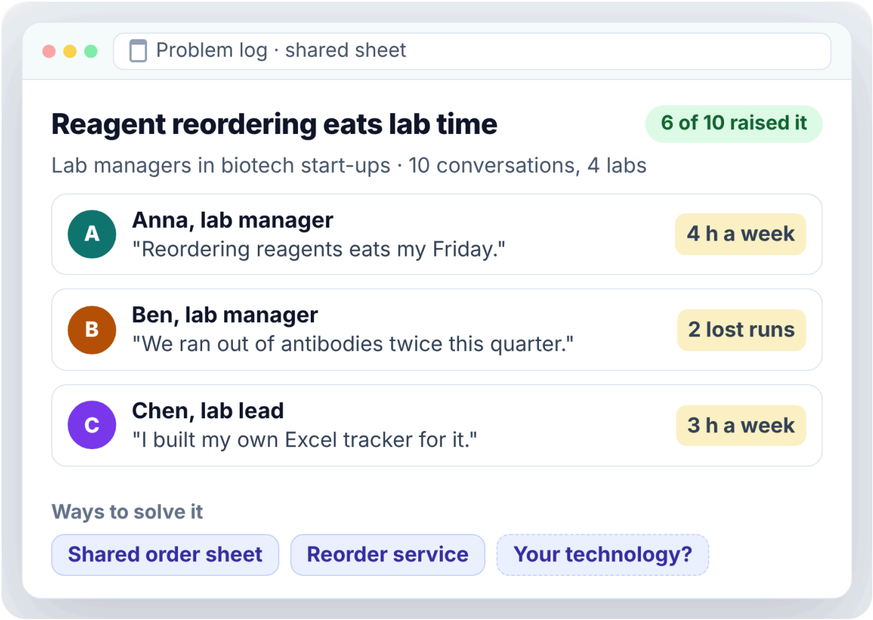
Technology first

a product looking for a problem



Problem first

a problem looking for the best way to solve it



YC Friedman, J. (2020). How to get startup ideas. YC Startup School. Mock-ups, product, people and numbers made up.

NOW YOU · ALONE · 3 MINUTES

Sort the advice you got

! KEEP OR UNLEARN

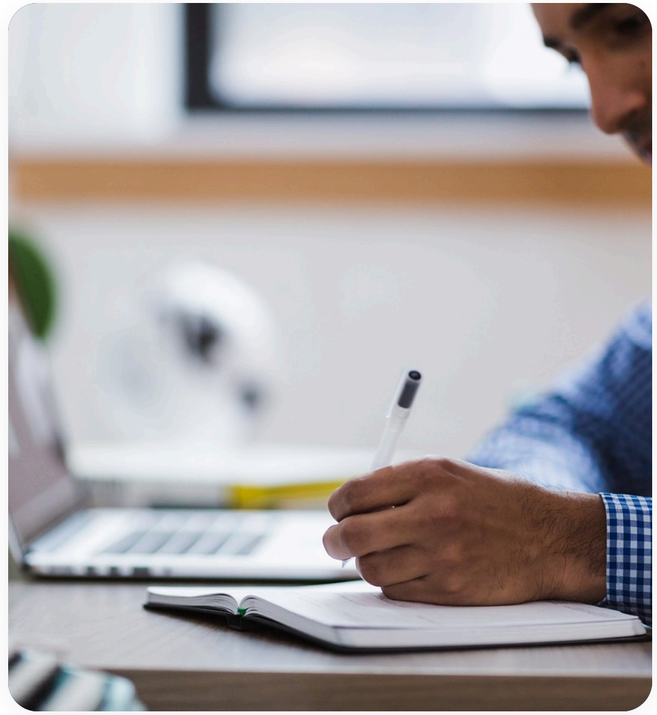
Three pieces of advice, three questions

You keep only advice that makes you learn from customers.

→ **Write** the three pieces of startup advice you heard most this year
→ **Note** who gave each. Did they ever found a company?
→ **Ask** of each: does it make me learn from customers, or collect something?
→ **Mark** each one keep or unlearn
→ Like: "File a patent first", a bank adviser who never founded. Unlearn

Output Three lines, each marked keep or unlearn

Minutes 3



3:00

"NOW IT'S EASY"

Every new tool made building easier. None made startups easy

"It's getting so cheap to start a startup." Paul Graham, 2005



Still open after five years · % of new US businesses



DATA Graham (2005). Gruber (2005) on Rails. AWS (2014) on S3. Node.js about page (2012). Bubble No-Code Census (2020). Karpathy (2025). U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, five-year survival of new establishments, bars to scale. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

THE SKILL NEVER CHANGED

Tech changes. The founder's job doesn't

Every wave needed people who turned it into something others pay for



Same job, something others pay for

Founding years from Wikipedia, retrieved 2026-10-19. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

Mistakes aren't a necessary evil. They aren't evil at all. They are an inevitable consequence of doing something new.

Ed Catmull, co-founder of **Pixar**



BOOK

Creativity, Inc.

Ed Catmull with Amy Wallace, 2014

FRAMEWORK Catmull, E., & Wallace, A. (2014). *Creativity, Inc.* Random House, as quoted by Popova (2014), The Marginalian. Photo: RaniRamli on Pixabay, a stock desk lamp, not a Pixar image.

INPUT 2 OF 3 · GROUND IT · THE ANSWERS

Ground it: a problem first, the rest can wait

1



What kills most startups?

No market need, the #1 reason in 101 post-mortems

2



Which advice can wait?

Patents, grants, followers and downloads. Count what customers did

3



Where should you start?

From a problem people have, not from your technology

Test it: one loop a week

You beat the big ones by learning faster, with Build-Measure-Learn and the hierarchy of evidence.

01 ~~Aim it: why now, and why you~~
02 ~~Ground it: start from a problem~~
03 Test it: one loop a week
04 How this course works
05 Wrap-up and check-out
06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

INPUT 3 OF 3 · TEST IT · THREE QUESTIONS

How do you learn faster?

1



How can a small team beat a big one?

2



What is your idea, really?

3



How fast should you test?

THE CASH CONSTRAINT

Your startup is a loop. It runs

cash>0

```
while (cash > 0) {
  learn();
}
```

Every week without learning burns runway.

WORKING WITH CONSTRAINTS

While BMW runs one loop, you can run twenty

No manpower, no money, no time. Also no inertia, no legacy, no politics



1 iteration legacy · politics · sign-offs

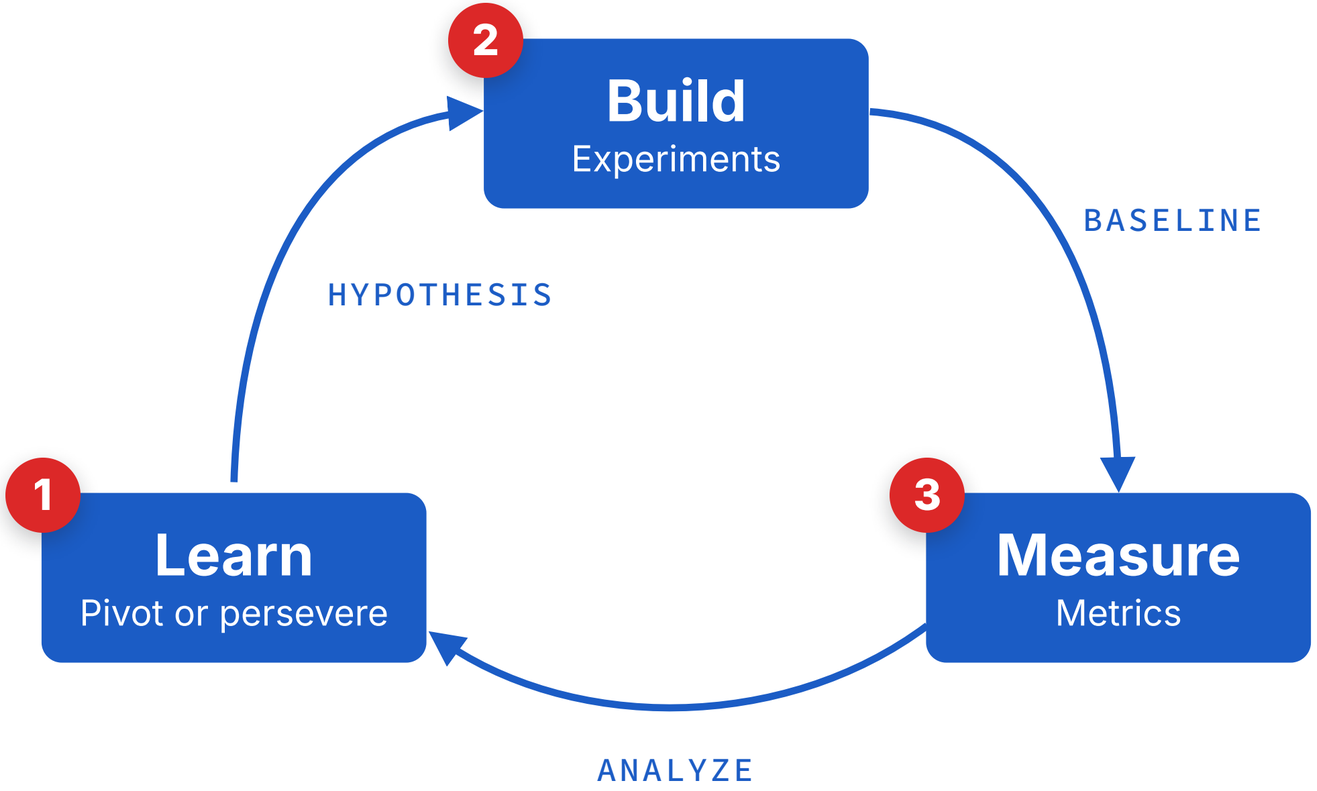


1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 **20**

ILLUSTRATIVE The 1 to 20 ratio is an illustration, not a measurement. Photos, not BMW's plant: marcin049 and StartupStockPhotos on Pixabay. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

CORNERSTONE · BUILD-MEASURE-LEARN

Start at Learn. Build only what you must test



Learn · start here
One hypothesis, the one that brings your next paying customer or a 10x step. Not a list

Build · only what tests it
As fast as you can. Building is cheap now, so brake

Measure · with real customers
A real customer opens the wallet. ChatGPT gives hints, but never pays

Building is no longer the bottleneck. Measuring is

FRAMEWORK Ries, E. (2011). *The Lean Startup*. Crown Business. Ries plans the loop in reverse, starting from what you need to learn.

IN DETAIL

Start at Learn. Build only what you must test

Learn: start here

Your own insight is the start. Pick the one hypothesis you believe brings you to your next paying customer, or to a 10x step. One, not a list. Learning is yours, nobody does it for you.

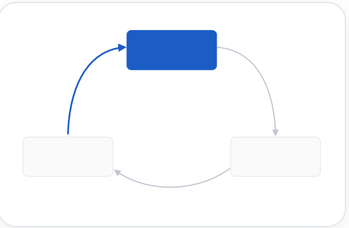
Build: only what tests it

Build the smallest thing that tests that one hypothesis, as fast as you can. With AI, building is cheap, so the skill is braking. Whatever extra you build gets measured too and blurs what you learn.

Measure: with real customers

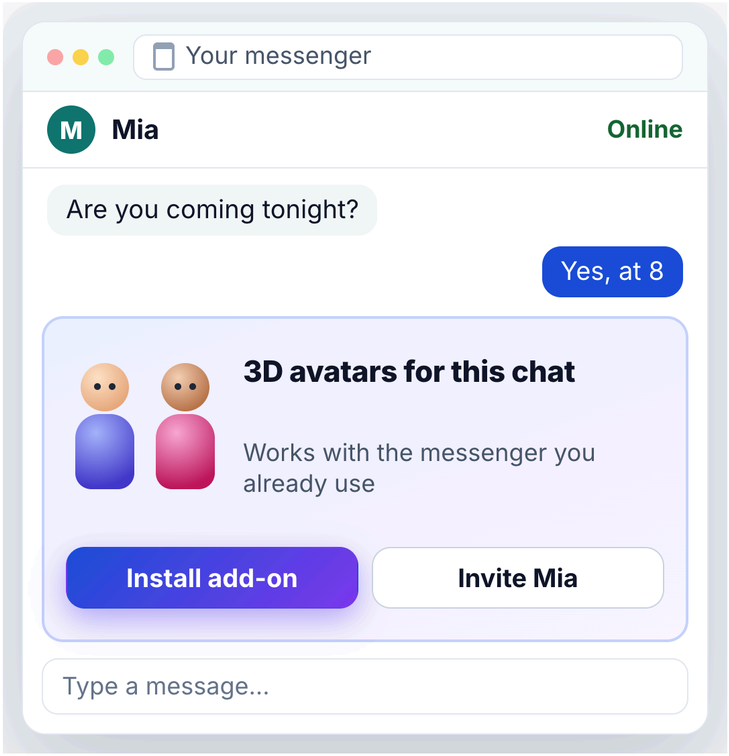
Only real customers count, and a real customer opens their wallet. ChatGPT can give you a hint, but ChatGPT is never your customer. It does not pay.

FRAMEWORK Ries, E. (2011). *The Lean Startup*. Crown Business. Ries plans the loop in reverse, starting from what you need to learn.



RIES'S OWN EXAMPLE · IMVU

Ries started at Build. It cost him six months



Build Six months, tens of thousands of lines of code

Measure A 17-year-old test user: "You want me to risk inviting my friends to a thing that I don't think is cool?"

Learn "We had to throw all that code away." A network of its own instead, $50 million a year by 2011

FRAMEWORK Ries (2009), interview, Mixergy. TechCrunch (2011) on the six months. The network of its own and the revenue from Ries (2011), *The Lean Startup*. Mock-up, not IMVU's real screen.

THE CORE OF THIS COURSE

Two ideas, two tools

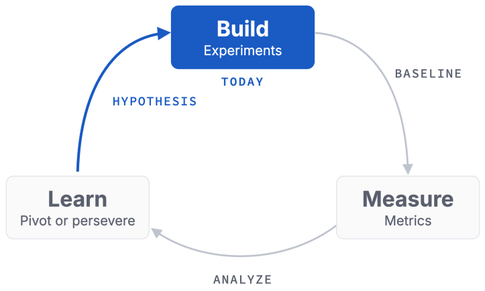
Everything in the next twelve weeks builds on these four

1 Speed matters

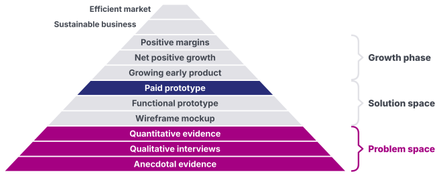
You beat the big ones only by learning faster

2 Validated learning beats opinions

Opinions are free. Evidence costs a conversation, a click, a payment



Build-Measure-Learn



Hierarchy of evidence

Build-Measure-Learn after Ries (2011), the hierarchy of evidence.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS · 4 RANDOMIZED TRIALS

Founders who test like scientists kill bad ideas sooner

759

startups in four randomized trials

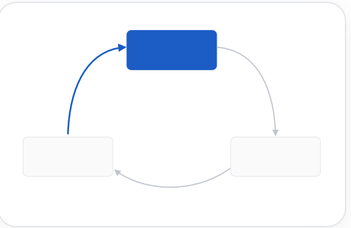
+9.8

points more ideas terminated

+€7k

more revenue per firm over 16 months, many earned none

RESEARCH Camuffo et al. (2024), Strategic Management Journal, 759 firms. First trial: Camuffo et al. (2020), Management Science, 116 startups.



THE PROBLEM HYPOTHESIS

Write hypotheses a stranger could prove wrong

A SOLUTION IN DISGUISE

"Scientists need an AI lab assistant."

A PROBLEM HYPOTHESIS

Lab managers in biotech start-ups struggle to track reagent orders when several teams order at once. Today they keep an Excel sheet, which costs them about 4 hours a week.

Student Toolkit · Experiment Tracker

Hypotheses, riskiest first — 3 of 3 written

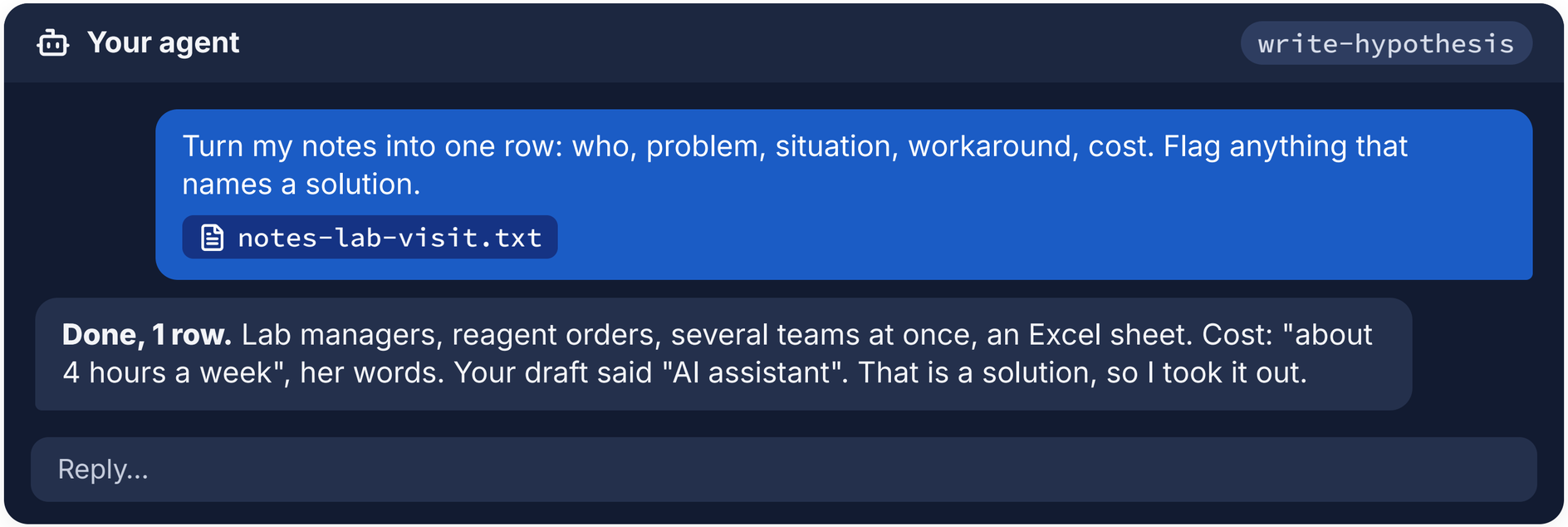
#	Hypothesis	Kill line	Evidence
1	**Lab managers** struggle to track reagent orders when several teams order at once. Excel sheet, about 4 h a week.	Under 3 of 10 raise it before I name it	Interviews
2	**Postdocs** lose a run when a reagent is out and nobody saw it coming. They borrow from next door.	Under 3 of 10 raise it before I name it	Anecdote
3	**Lab leads** cannot see what each team spends on reagents. They ask at month end.	Under 3 of 10 raise it before I name it	My opinion

The first 10 conversations go to number 1

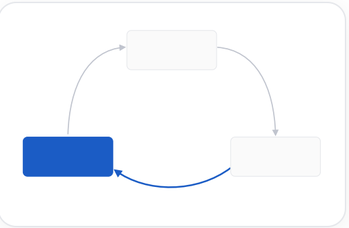
ILLUSTRATIVE Form and example from the Kickoff (M00) workshop. Mock-up and chat made up.

WITH YOUR AGENT

Write hypotheses a stranger could prove wrong



ILLUSTRATIVE Form and example from the Kickoff (M00) workshop. Mock-up and chat made up.



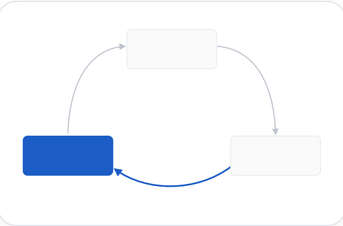
DISCIPLINED ENTREPRENEURSHIP · 24 STEPS

24 steps feel safe. It's still one loop

Each step is Build-Measure-Learn. Steps 20 and 21 meet reality

1 Market segmentation	**2** Select a beachhead market	**3** Build an end user profile	**4** TAM for the beachhead	**5** Persona for the beachhead	**6** Full life cycle use case
7 High-level product specification	**8** Quantify the value proposition	**9** Identify your next 10 customers	**10** Define your core	**11** Chart your competitive position	**12** Determine the customer organisation
13 Map how to acquire a paying customer	**14** TAM for follow-on markets	**15** Design a business model	**16** Set your pricing framework	**17** Calculate the unit economics	**18** Map the sales process
19 Calculate the customer economics	**20** Identify key assumptions	**21** Test key assumptions	**22** Define the MVP	**23** Prove your beachhead with your MVP	**24** Develop a product plan

FRAMEWORK Aulet, B. (2013). *Disciplined Entrepreneurship: 24 Steps to a Successful Startup*. Wiley. Step names, shortened.



REALITY CHECK

Every plan feels safe until reality hits back



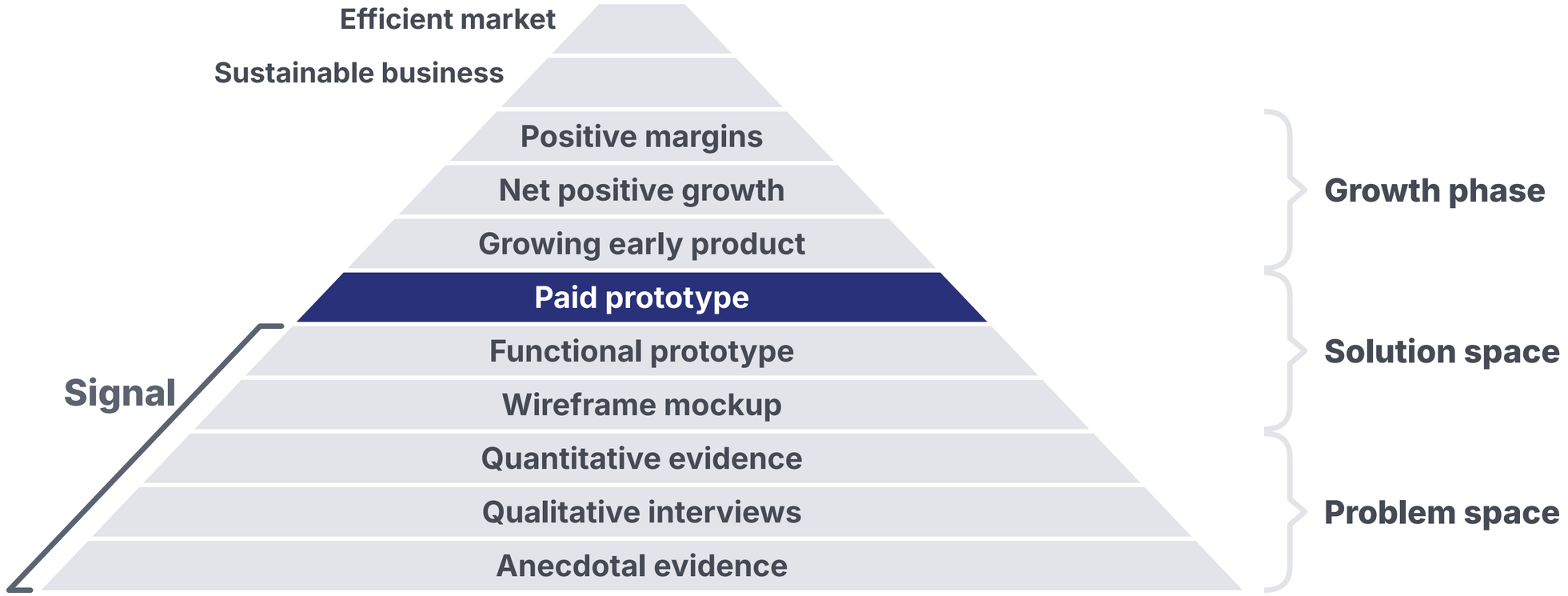
Everybody has a 24-step plan until reality punches them in the face.

After Mike Tyson

After Mike Tyson (1987), "Everybody has plans until they get hit for the first time." GIF.

CORNERSTONE · HIERARCHY OF EVIDENCE

It's a signal until somebody pays



IN DETAIL

It's a signal until somebody pays

Anecdotal evidence. One person tells you something, or you lived it yourself. Enough to start looking, never enough to decide.

Qualitative interviews. Conversations about the last time the problem happened. They build your theory: who has the problem, what it costs, what they do today.

Quantitative evidence. Tests how strong the effect is that your interviews suggested: how many in your segment act on it. A survey about past behaviour, or a landing page that counts clicks.

Wireframe mockup. A quick thing that only shows how the solution could look. People react to it, nothing works yet.

Functional prototype. It works. A slice of the product solves the problem for real users, even if you run parts of it by hand.

Paid prototype. Somebody opens their wallet for it. The first rung that counts as validation, everything below is signal.

Growing early product. Customers pay again and new ones arrive. The question moves from whether it works to whether it grows.

Net positive growth. You win more customers than you lose, month after month.

Positive margins. Each sale earns more than it costs to deliver.

Sustainable business. The business carries itself, without your next funding round.

Efficient market. Others copy you and prices settle. By now everyone has the evidence, and so does every competitor.

Problem space. Rungs 1 to 3. Is the problem real, who has it, and how many?

Solution space. Rungs 4 to 6. Does your solution solve it, and will someone pay?

Growth phase. Rungs 7 to 9. Does it work as a business, again and again?

HANDS UP · 1 MINUTE

What backs your idea today?

Rate the belief you wrote on the tier list



Opinion

my own



Anecdote

somebody told me



Conversation

I asked and listened



Payment

somebody paid

1:00

SPEED MATTERS

Speed matters:

Ship weekly

SPEED MATTERS

Every week, you can talk to at least

15 relevant users



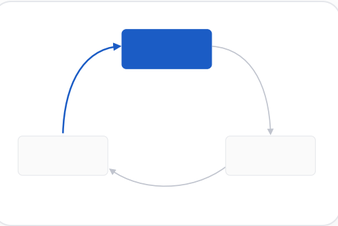
15 a week is 3 a day.

The full bar until Team (M01).

SPEED MATTERS

One step should not take more than

4 hours



NOW YOU · ALONE · 2 MINUTES

What's your fastest test on a real person?

! FROM TODAY

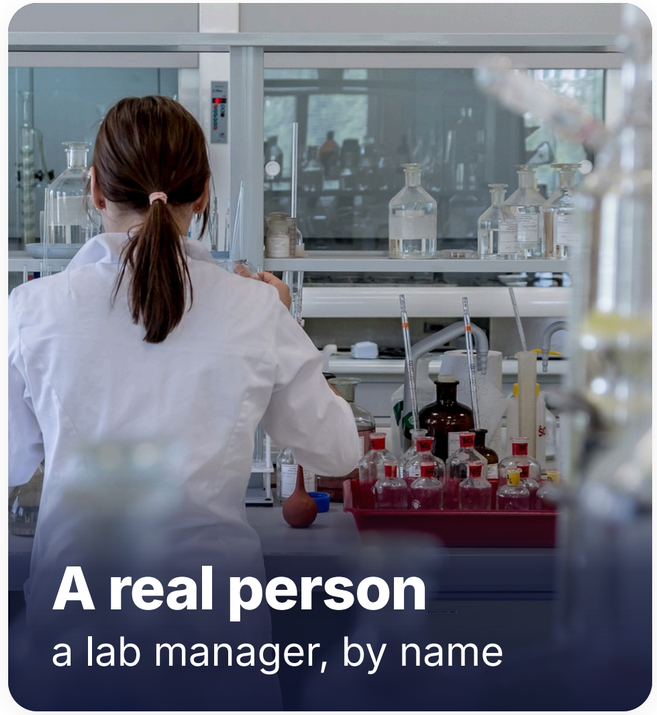
Before you build anything

The smallest thing that reaches a real person by Friday.

→ Who exactly? A name, not a segment
→ What do you ask or show them?
→ Which day do you do it?
→ Like: "Call three lab managers from my old institute on Thursday"

Output One test, one name, one day

Minutes 2



2:00

ILLUSTRATIVE Example continues the lab example of this deck. Photo: jarmoluk on Pixabay.

INPUT 3 OF 3 · TEST IT · THE ANSWERS

Test it: one loop a week

1



How can a small team beat a big one?

By learning faster. While BMW runs one loop, you can run twenty

2



What is your idea, really?

A hypothesis a stranger could prove wrong, and a signal until somebody pays

3



How fast should you test?

Ship weekly, talk to 15 users a week, no step over 4 hours

CHAPTER 4 OF 6

How this course works

Thirteen weeks built for speed, ending with a team, a validated idea and first revenue.

01 ~~Aim it: why now, and why you~~
02 ~~Ground it: start from a problem~~
03 ~~Test it: one loop a week~~
04 **How this course works**
05 Wrap-up and check-out
06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

COURSE PATH

Thirteen weeks from first leads to first euros

The best teams make more than **€10,000** in revenue along the way

00 **Kickoff**
your first sales leads

01 **Team & foundations**
one shared problem space

02 **Finding ideas**
the first names on your prospect list

03 **The problem space**
your first prospects

04 **Validating problems**
your first testers and buyers

05 **The solution space**
MVP spec + deployed Weekend Build

06 **Prototyping with AI**
deployed prototype + 10 non-friend reactions

07 **The kill decision**
provisional verdict

08 **Finding first users**
first revenue from strangers

09 **Prototype to product**
more revenue

10 **Product management**
more revenue

11 **Founder health**
more revenue

12 **Fundraising & demo day**
verified revenue

HOW A WEEK RUNS

Every module offers three blocks

Each block works on its own, about 90 minutes each



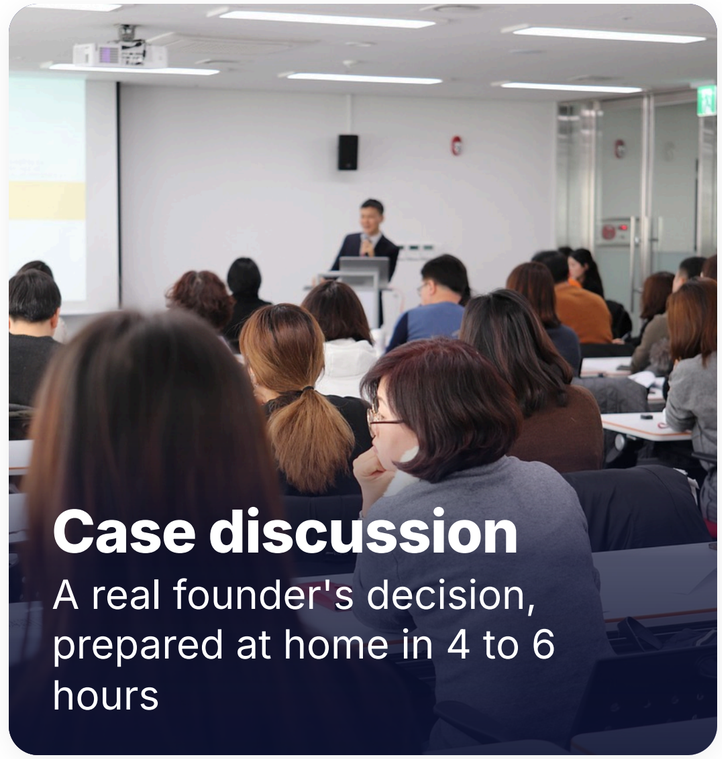
Input session

Check-in, recap, your read-out, new content, wrap-up



Workshop

You start the week's work on your own venture



Case discussion

A real founder's decision, prepared at home in 4 to 6 hours

Photos: nikolayhg, StockSnap and LeeJeongSoo on Pixabay.

FROM TEAM (M01) ON · EVERY SESSION

Show us where you're at in 3 minutes or less!

3:00

Facts

Statistics or research

What do they say, and where are they from?

12 Numbers

Usage or surveys

How did they change, and why does it matter?

Quotes

Interviews

What did they say, and why?

Images

Screenshots or users

What happened, and what changed?

Start with your target against your actual

What did you do? | **What did you learn?** | **How can we help?**

ACCOUNTABILITY

Every week, your target against your actual



User interactions?

What did you learn?



New revenue?

Why did they pay?



Shipped?

Why does it matter?

🦄 **Report target vs. actual. Say candidly why you hit it or missed it**

THE TRAP

Busy feels like progress. Mostly it isn't

Five full days. Which one would a customer notice?

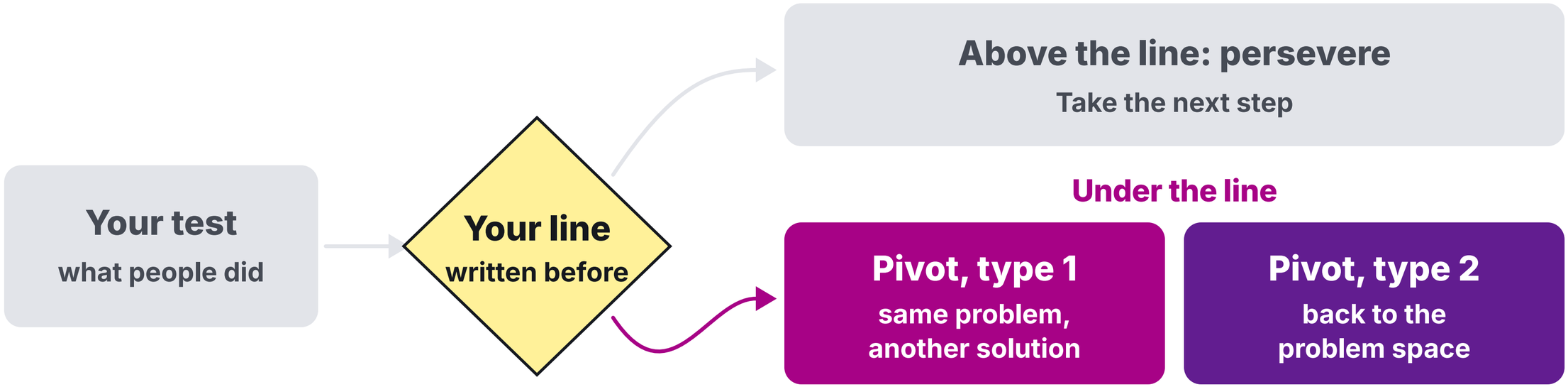
	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI
	New logo	Grant form	Pitch deck version 5	Competitor list	Call 5 customers
Felt busy	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
A customer noticed	✗	✗	✗	✗	✓

YC "It's very easy to feel busy and feel productive and not be moving your business forward." Divya Bhat, YC Startup School. The week is made up.

PIVOT OR PERSEVERE

Under your line? That is a decision, not a failure

From today, every test ends in one of two moves, and both are progress



Both are progress. The only miss: no line, so no decision

FRAMEWORK Pivot or persevere after Ries, E. (2011), The Lean Startup. Pivot types as in the course Glossary.

THE GROUP

Three to seven teams. Every two weeks. One goal each

Informal, short and candid. No slides, numbers first



3–7 teams at your pace

2 weeks between meetings

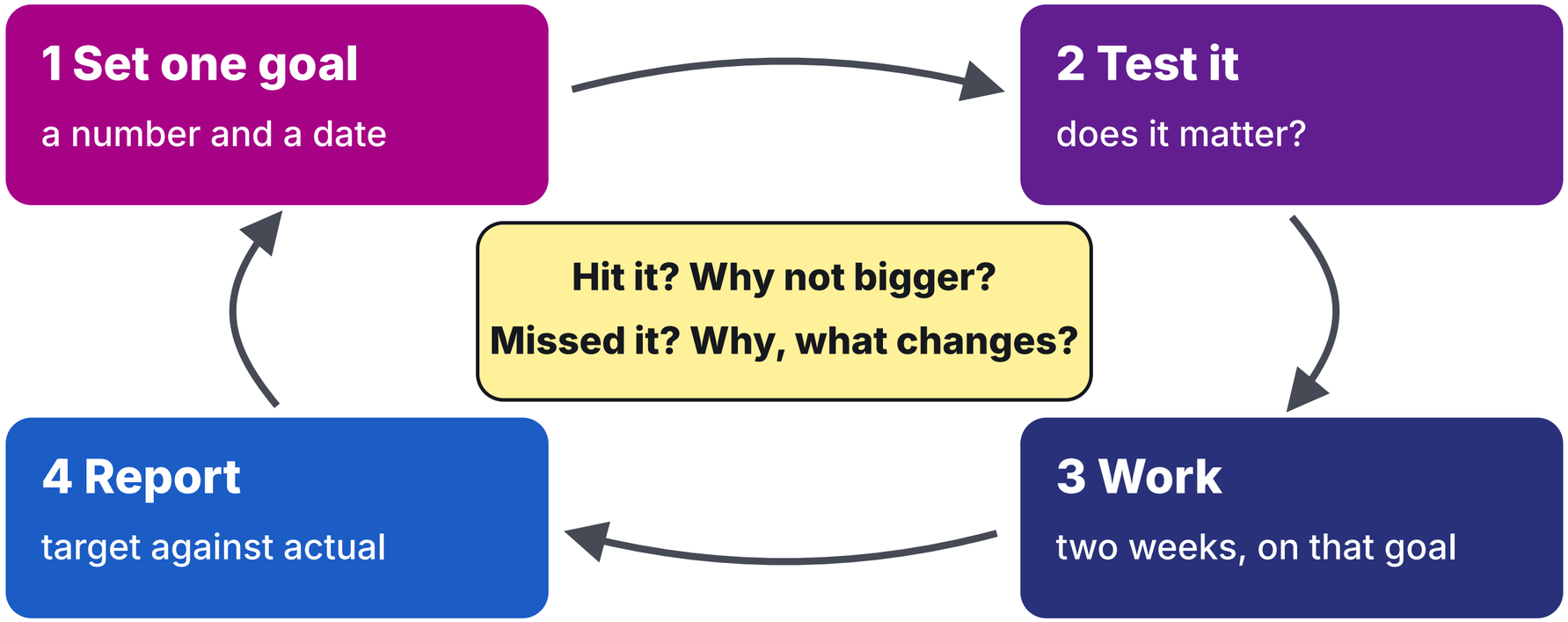
45 minutes at most

1 goal per team

Run your group with the Accountability Group Tracker in the course resources.
Photo: StartupStockPhotos on Pixabay.

THE TWO-WEEK CYCLE

Set it, test it, do it, then answer for it



THE GOAL TEST

Test every goal before you work on it

Two no's, and the team rewrites it before the meeting ends

	Learning? Will we know something about customers that we don't know today?		**Revenue?** Does it bring a paying customer closer?		**Lasting?** Does it build a business that can carry itself?	
WEAK **"Apply for EXIST"**	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No
GOOD **"3 of our 10 hottest prospects pay for a pilot in two weeks"**	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No

THE CANDID RULE

Hit every goal? Then they were too small

Average share of target over several cycles, to scale. Zones are a rule of thumb



Hit them all? You set them too small. Nobody checks your goals but you, so aim at two in three.

YC Sandbagging after Seibel and Caldwell, YC, Setting smarter goals. The sweet spot is Google's rule of thumb for stretch goals (re:Work), not a research finding. Zone limits from the course's group tracker.

THE ONE QUESTION

Every two weeks, the same question

Asked by your group, answered with a number

What was your goal for the last two weeks?

Did you hit it?

If not, what got in the way?

Your group asks it. You answer with the number first

2.5 to 3×

the effect when progress is reported

138 randomized studies, 19,951 people

+8.1%

revenue, managers in peer groups

2,800 Chinese firms, randomized

2 weeks

short enough that nobody hides

RESEARCH Harkin, B., et al. (2016). Psychological Bulletin, reported against private progress. Cai, J., & Szeidl, A. (2018). Quarterly Journal of Economics. The two-week rhythm follows YC's group office hours (Alströmer, 2023, Lenny's Podcast).

THE TOOL

Run the group from one spreadsheet

Left half when you set the goal, right half two weeks later

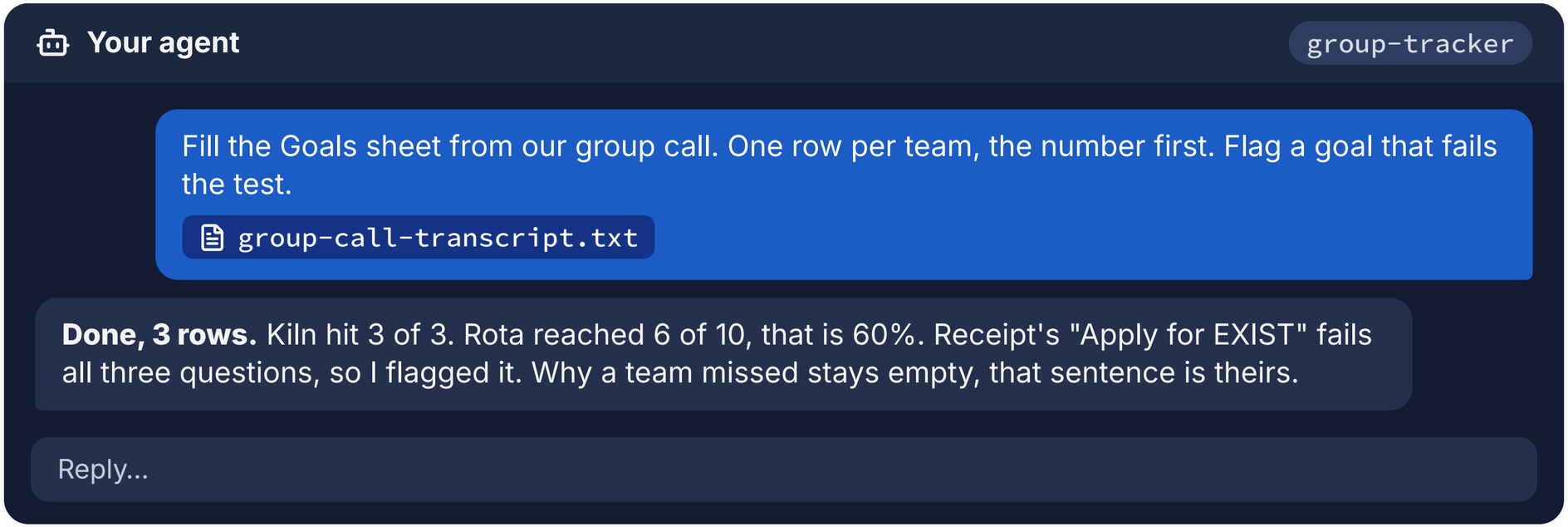
Team	Two-week goal (one sentence, with a number and a date)	Target	Learning?	Revenue?	Lasting?	Group: ambition	Actual	Share of target	Result
Team Kiln	Get 3 of our 10 hottest prospects to pay for a two-week pilot in two weeks	3	Yes	Yes	Yes	Right	3	100%	Hit
Team Rota	Hold 30 problem conversations with care-home shift leads, 10 next steps, in two weeks	10	Yes	Yes	No	Right	6	60%	Missed
Team Receipt	Apply for EXIST	1	No	No	No	Too small			

> The sheet flags a goal that fails the test, and the scoreboard says when to raise the bar

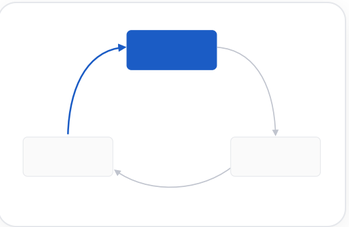
ILLUSTRATIVE Download the Accountability Group Tracker from the course repository. Screenshot 2026-10-20, teams and goals made up. Chat made up.

WITH YOUR AGENT

Run the group from one spreadsheet



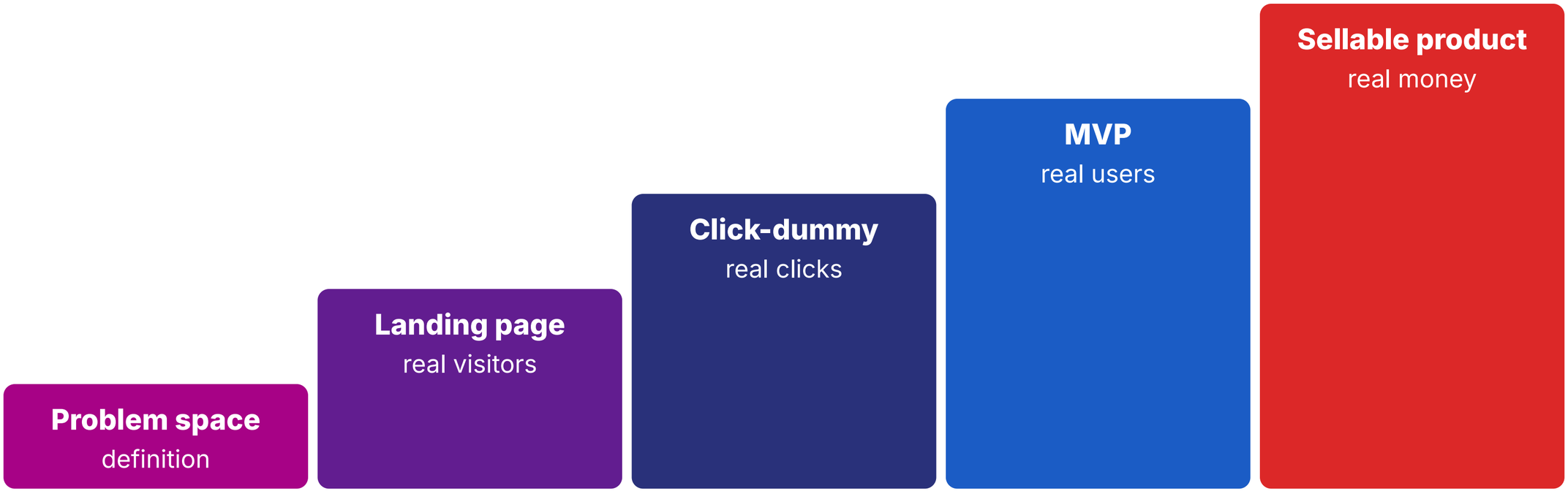
ILLUSTRATIVE Download the Accountability Group Tracker from the course repository. Screenshot 2026-10-20, teams and goals made up. Chat made up.



THE WORKSHOP LADDER

Your work climbs five rungs toward real users

Your results are for users to interact with



HOW YOU'RE GRADED

Evidence and decisions weigh as much as revenue

You're not graded on sticking to your idea

The rubric · drawn to scale

Evidence quality	Decision discipline	Verified traction	Commu-nication
30%	30%	30%	10%

A well-argued kill with a documented evidence pack can earn an A.

A VERY GOOD RESULT IS A GROWING STARTUP

Work on what you control

Things you can control

- Talk to 15 users each week
- Present your progress every week and ask for help
- Offer critical feedback and questions
- Be an expert in your problem space
- Pivot when you hit a brick wall

Things you can't totally control

- Steady growth on your landing page
- A lead list of potential users
- Paying customers

HOW WE WORK TOGETHER

Coachability, accountability, bias to action. Or be elsewhere

1

Together we grow: coachability

We give candid and productive feedback. We listen and seek to understand.

2

We act as we say: accountability

We stick to our word where it's in our hands. We learn from failures where it's not.

3

Give first, dream first: bias to action

We prefer building and experimenting over understanding every aspect.

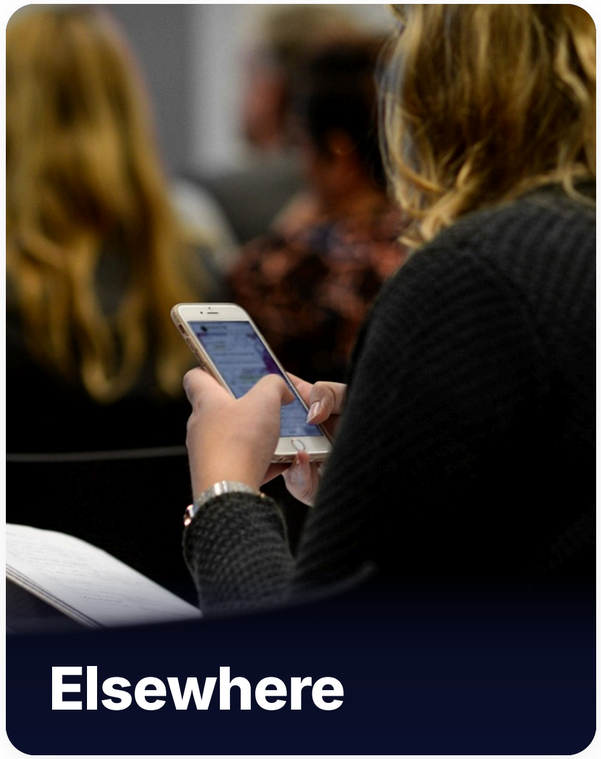


Photo: ClickerHappy on Pixabay.

DOS AND DON'TS IN THIS SEMINAR

Pivoting is fine. A knowingly bad idea isn't

Totally fine

- Building wild ideas
- Regrouping
- Pivoting
- Failing

Not OK in here

- Sticking with a knowingly bad idea
- Being late
- Missing class
- Staying silent when you don't understand

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

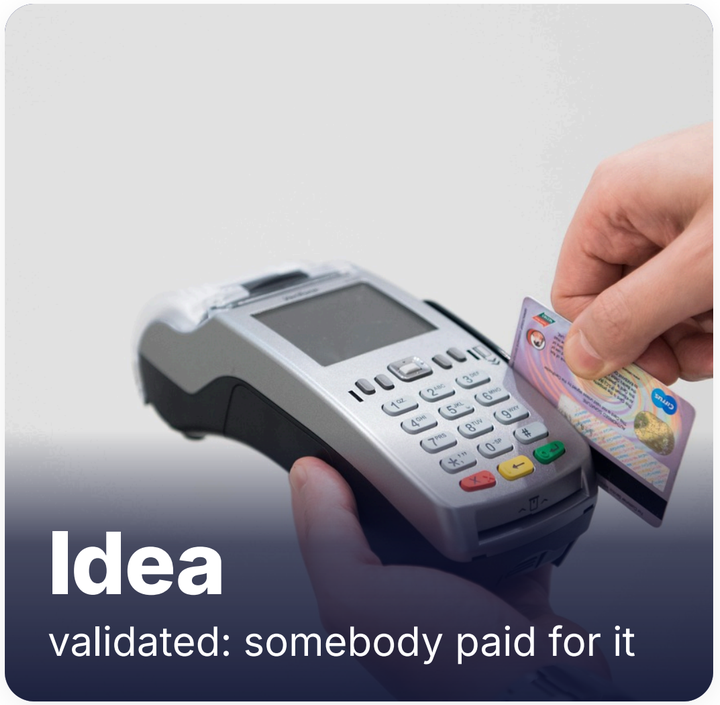
A team, a validated idea and first revenue

The best teams make more than €10,000 along the way



Team

2 to 4 people who commit to each other



Idea

validated: somebody paid for it



€

first revenue in the bank

"Validated" as in the course glossary: somebody opens their wallet. Photos: RonaldCandonga, AhmadArdity and moerschy on Pixabay.

WHAT WE ARE WORKING TOWARDS · THE SEQUOIA PITCH

Every phase earns part of your pitch

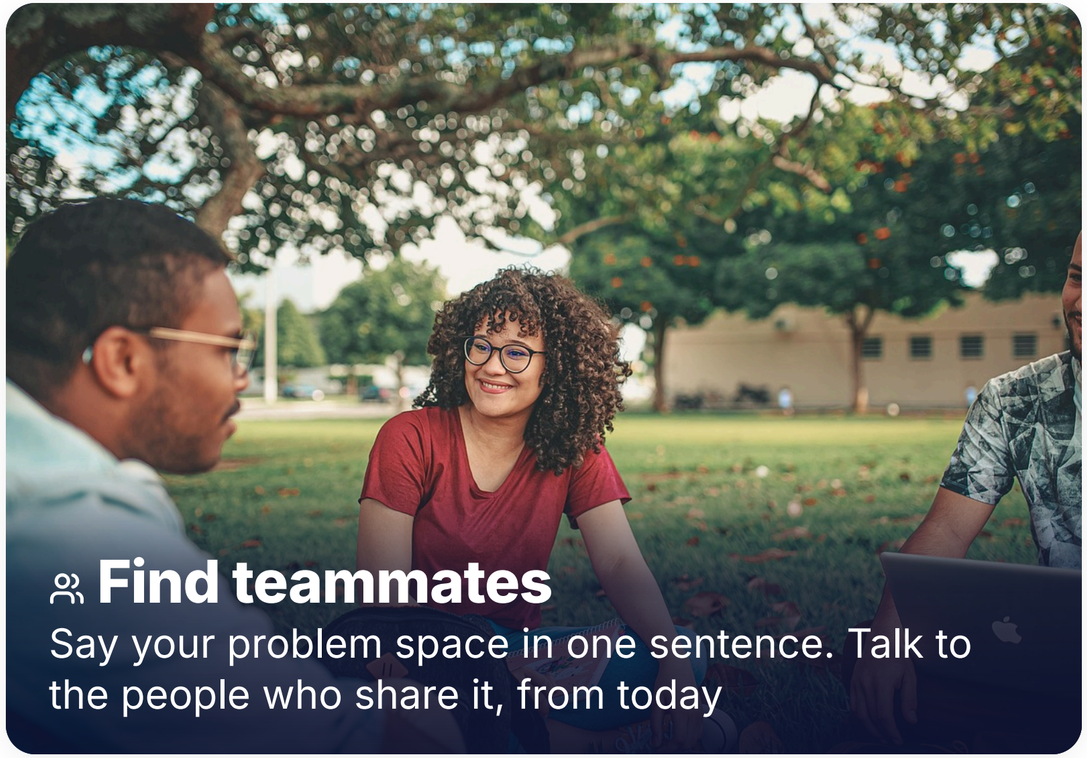
1	Company purpose	COVER
2	Problem	PROBLEM
3	Solution	SOLUTION
4	Why now?	PROBLEM
5	Market potential	COVER
6	Competition	PROBLEM
7	Business model	SOLUTION
8	Team	COVER
9	Financials	
10	Vision	
11	Roadmap	COVER

Sequoia Capital

FRAMEWORK Sequoia Capital (2019), Writing a business plan, ten sections. Course material, plus Bastian's roadmap.

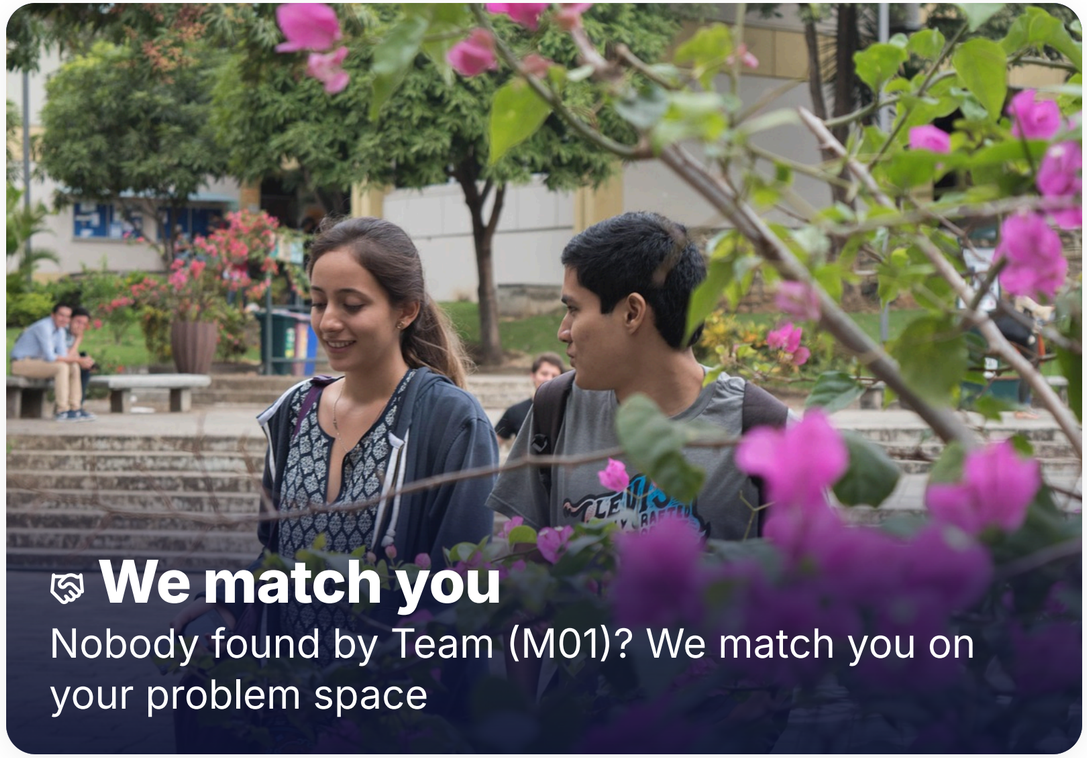
TEAMS FORM BY TEAM (M01)

Find teammates now, or we match you



Find teammates

Say your problem space in one sentence. Talk to the people who share it, from today



We match you

Nobody found by Team (M01)? We match you on your problem space

Photos: naassomz1 and vicwag on Pixabay.

CHAPTER 5 OF 6

Wrap-up and check-out

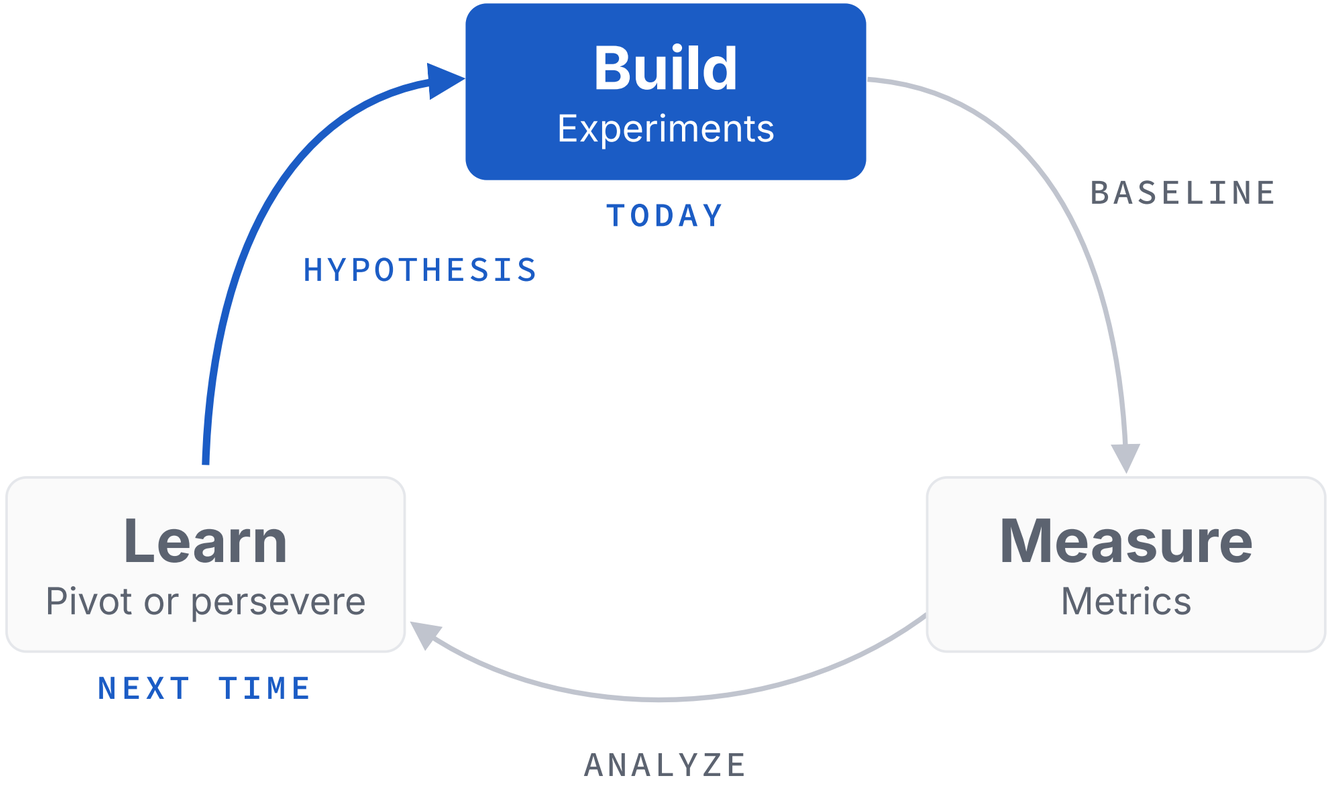
What you take home today, and the fifteen conversations that start today.

01 ~~Aim it: why now, and why you~~
02 ~~Ground it: start from a problem~~
03 ~~Test it: one loop a week~~
04 ~~How this course works~~
05 **Wrap-up and check-out**
06 Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies

RECAP · CORNERSTONE

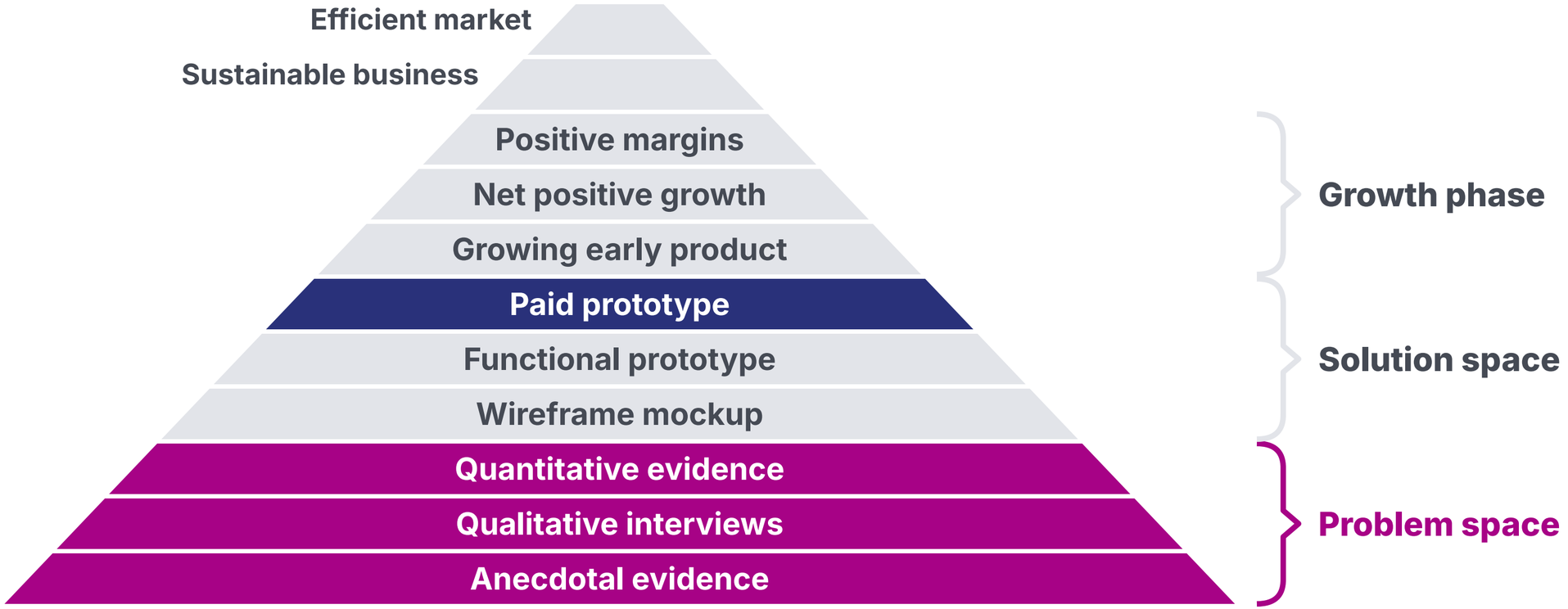
One full turn by next time, not this semester

You started today. Close it by Team (M01)



RECAP · CORNERSTONE

Climb from opinions to a payment



REFLECTION 1 OF 3 · THE CONTENT

What could you apply?



What could you apply?



What gave you a hard time?

REFLECTION 2 OF 3 · THE PROCESS

Man vs. machine



Where did AI actually help you?



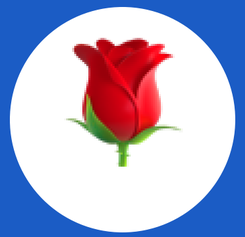
Where was your genius needed?



What are your best hacks to share?

REFLECTION 3 OF 3 · THE RESULTS

Rose, thorn, bud



What was the breakthrough today?



What was the hardest part today?



What is an idea/feature you didn't have time to finish, but want to explore later?

HOMEWORK UNTIL TEAM (M01)

Write 3 problem hypotheses and hold 15 problem conversations with named people, learning what the problem costs each of them today, and come back with 3 people who agreed to a next step.

15 conversations

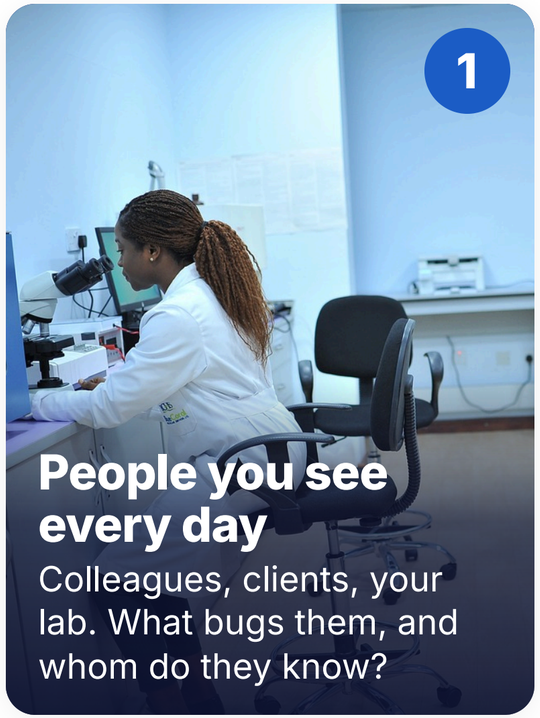
The learning floor is 3 hypotheses and 5 conversations with 1 next step.

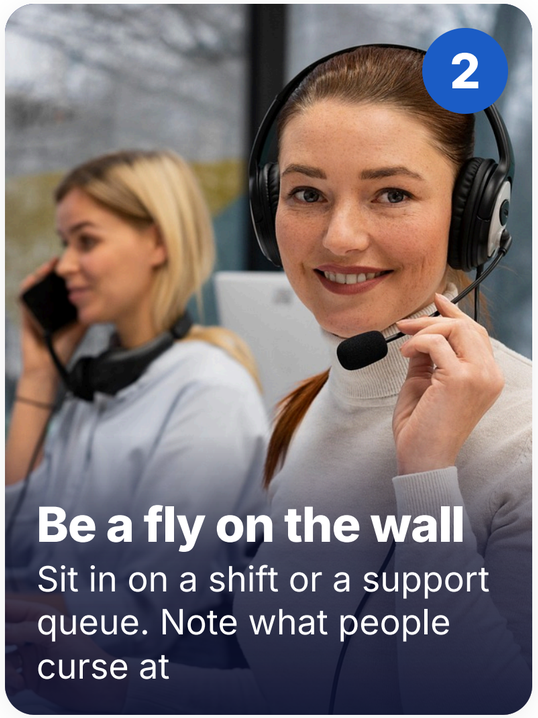
Log your kill line before your first conversation.

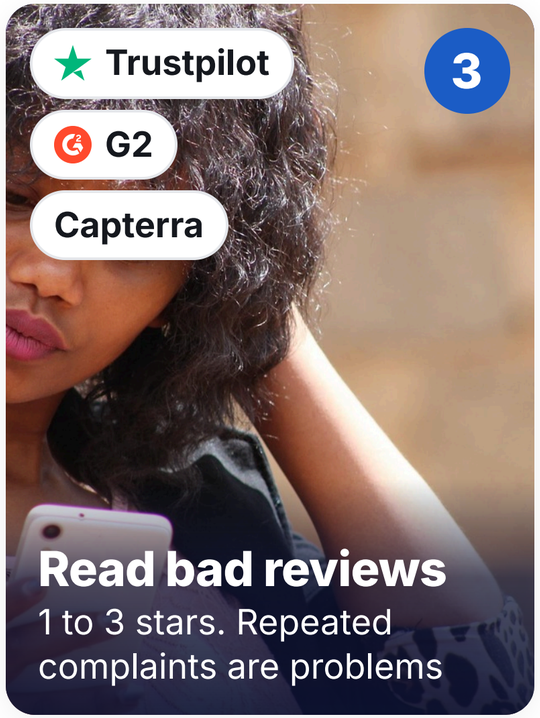
HOMEWORK · HOW TO

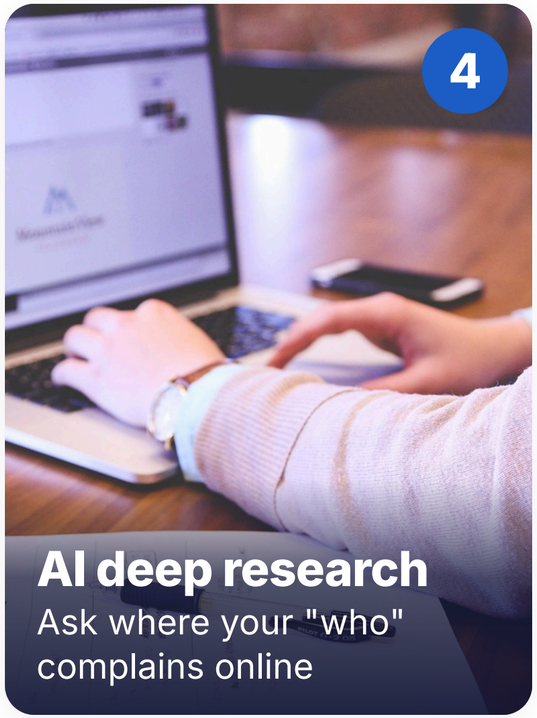
Find your people where they already are

Fifteen conversations means three a day. Start today









Photos: dmchannelsng, Telesolutionscallcentr, antonynjoro and StartupStockPhotos on Pixabay. Logos are trademarks of their owners.

HOMEWORK · WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

Dig deeper, or move on

A narrow, deep well: a few people want it fixed badly. A made-up example

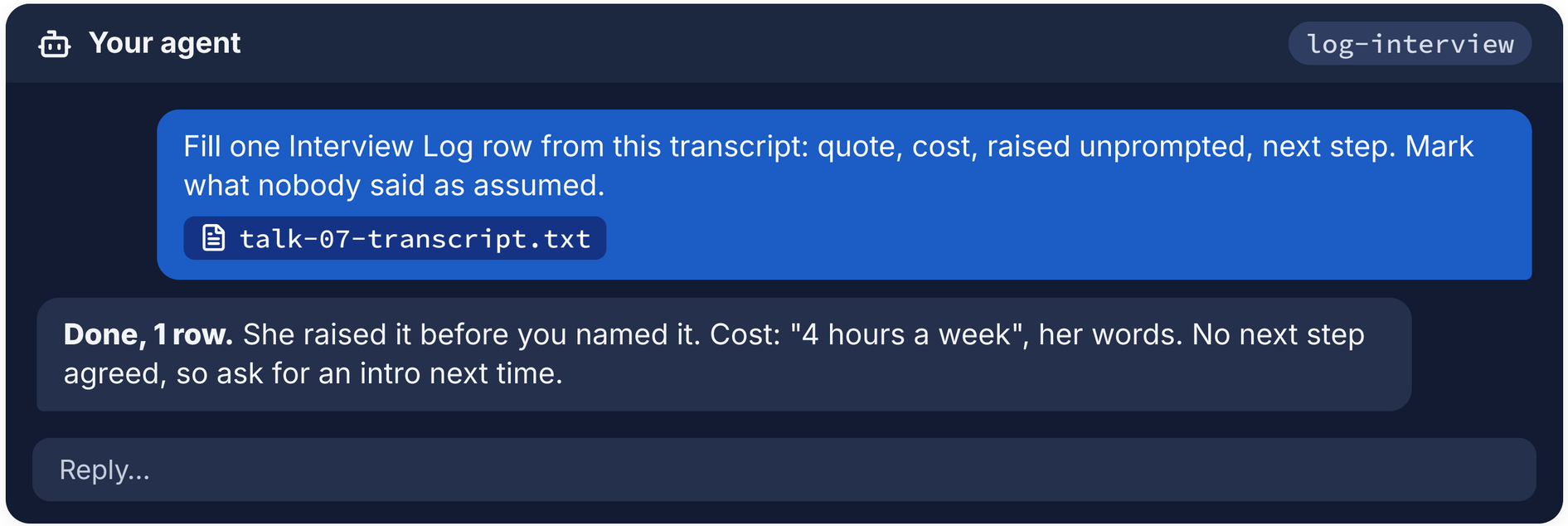
	DIG DEEPER	MOVE ON
Who	Lab managers in biotech start-ups	"Researchers"
Raised	4 of 10, before I named it	Only once I named it
Cost	4 hours a week, 2 built Excel trackers	"Annoying, but we live with it"
How many	6 of 10, in 4 labs	Me and my flatmate



ILLUSTRATIVE Kickoff (M00) homework, "What you come back with", made-up example, chat made up. "Narrow, deep well" after Graham (2012). Photo: dmchannelsng on Pixabay.

WITH YOUR AGENT

Dig deeper, or move on



ILLUSTRATIVE Kickoff (M00) homework, "What you come back with", made-up example, chat made up. "Narrow, deep well" after Graham (2012). Photo: dmchannelsng on Pixabay.

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See you in Team (M01), with names and numbers!

MODULE 00 · WORKSHOP · 90 MINUTES

Workshop: Autopsy your startup before it dies

Find what could kill your idea, write hypotheses you can lose, and reach real people today.

What kills startups, and what will this course demand from you?

01 ~~Aim it: why now, and why you~~
02 ~~Ground it: start from a problem~~
03 ~~Test it: one loop a week~~
04 ~~How this course works~~
05 ~~Wrap-up and check-out~~
06 **Workshop: autopsy your startup before it dies**

WORKSHOP · STEP 1 OF 3

Autopsy your own startup

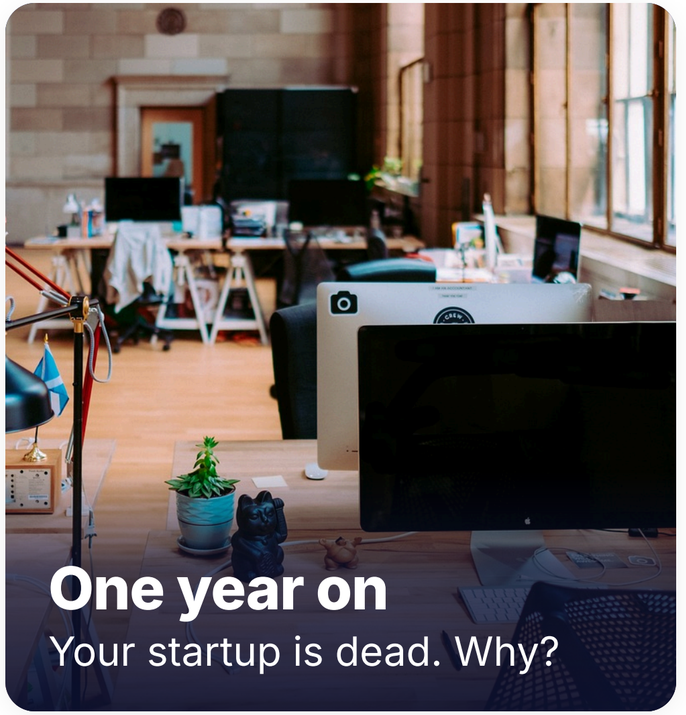
1 STEP 1 · 25 MIN

AUTOPSY YOUR OWN STARTUP

Find the customer assumption that kills your idea

→ Your starting point in one line
→ One year on, your startup is dead. Why?
→ Each cause becomes "We assumed ..."
→ Circle the riskiest untested one
→ Pairs: "How do you know?"

Output Riskiest untested assumption, in the Weekly Reflection **Minutes** 25



25:00

Photo: StockSnap on Pixabay.

WORKSHOP · STEP 2 OF 3

Write hypotheses you can lose

2 STEP 2 · 25 MIN

WRITE HYPOTHESES YOU CAN LOSE

Hypotheses a stranger could prove wrong

→ 3 hypotheses: who, problem, situation, workaround, cost
→ Rate the evidence: opinion, anecdote, conversation, payment
→ Rank them, riskiest first, start AI deep research
→ Kill line logged before any contact

Output 3 ranked hypotheses, their evidence, a kill line

Minutes 25



25:00

Photo: congerdesign on Pixabay.

WORKSHOP · STEP 3 OF 3

Reach real people, then commit

3 STEP 3 · 40 MIN

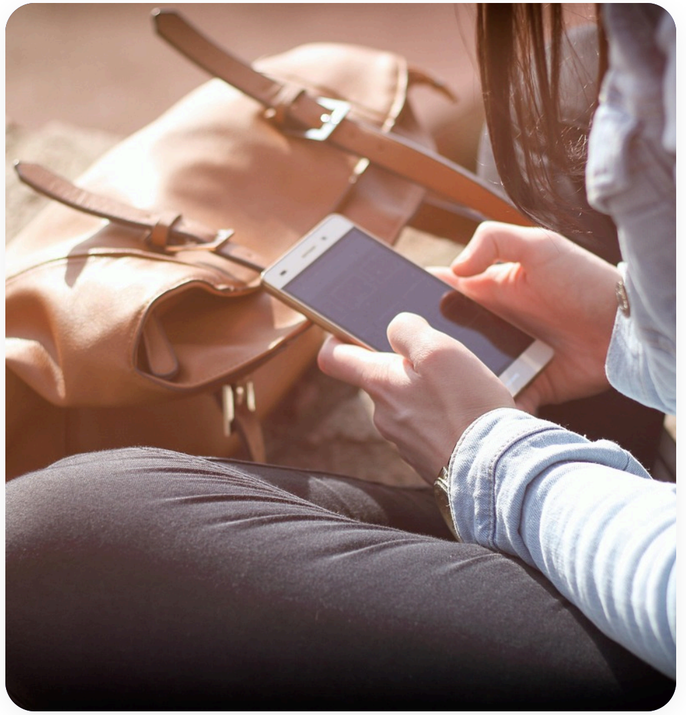
REACH REAL PEOPLE, THEN COMMIT

Leave with the week already moving

→ 10 min: pick named people from your research
→ 15 min: 5 messages to named people, or one call
→ Don't name your problem, do NOT pitch
→ 10 min: floor or full bar, midweek pace
→ 5 min: your problem space in one sentence, find teammates

Output Messages sent, target, pace, possible teammates

Minutes 40



40:00

ARRIVED EMPTY-HANDED?

No idea yet? Run the autopsy on a frustration you watched someone fight last month.

1 real frustration

HOMEWORK UNTIL TEAM (M01)

Write 3 problem hypotheses and hold 15 problem conversations with named people, learning what the problem costs each of them today, and come back with 3 people who agreed to a next step.

15 conversations

The learning floor is 3 hypotheses and 5 conversations with 1 next step.

Log your kill line before your first conversation.

See you in Team (M01), with names and numbers!